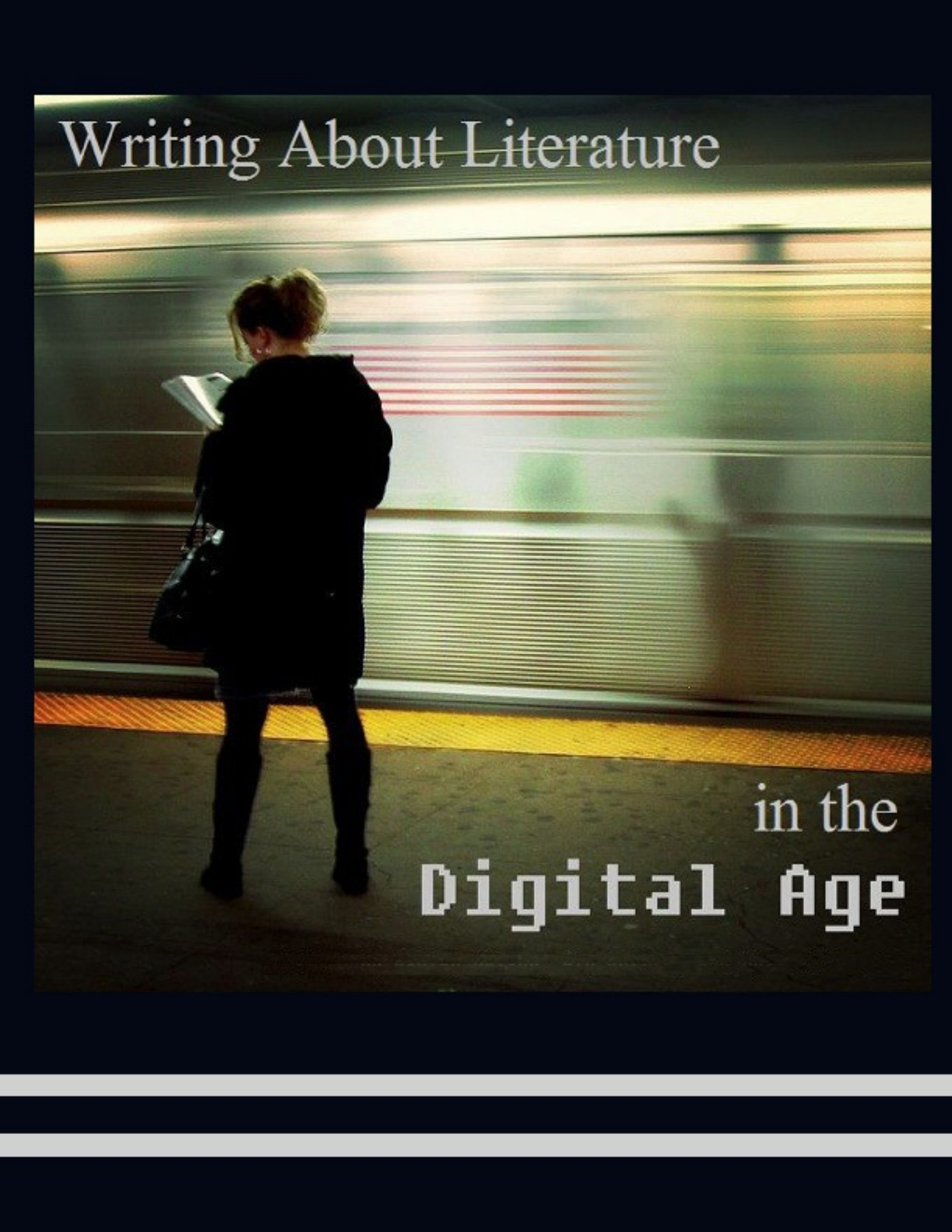


A person with blonde hair in a ponytail, wearing a dark coat and carrying a bag, stands on a train platform. They are holding and reading a book. A train is blurred in the background, moving from left to right. The platform has a yellow safety line. The scene is lit with warm, golden light, possibly from the setting or rising sun.

Writing About Literature

in the
Digital Age



Writing About Literature in the Digital Age

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Introduction: Welcoming the Digital Disruption to Literary Studies

by Gideon Burton

If the book we are reading doesn't wake us up with a blow on the head,
what are we reading it for? ...

A book must be the axe for the frozen sea inside us.

—Franz Kafka, Letter to Oskar Pollak, January 27, 1904

Literature is “equipment for living.”

—Kenneth Burke, *The Philosophy of Literary Form*, 1941

This eBook is intended for all those who value literary studies and who sense the coming change in how books are read, discussed, and written about in the digital age. It is a collaborative project, produced by students of an advanced writing course at Brigham Young University taught by Gideon Burton in May and June of 2011. This is not a professionally produced scholarly collection nor a grant-funded study. It is an experiment in eBook creation and in twenty-first century literary criticism.

Our adventure into digital literary study has been sudden and frenetic, and the ragged edges are likely to show. But we have pressed on, pushing bravely back against second thoughts, intent to launch our little volume into the marketplace of ideas where it may reach real people who are wrestling with the powerful disruptions to reading and writing now in play. A good book, as Kafka said, can wake us like a blow to the head. So can a vigorous literary experiment. We feel a bit battered, but far more awake to the present moment and to the ongoing vitality of literature as “equipment for living” in the digital age.

I'm writing this introduction as a house-sized pig floats above my home. It's Art City Days again in Springville, Utah, and the hot air balloon event is underway. I'm used to its excitement now, but that was not the case years ago. My introduction to the balloon festival was anything but calm.

I lay sleeping that early summer morning, my head near the open window of our bedroom, not aware that one of the hot air balloons from the festival had drifted, descending, until its basket was only a few feet above our roof.

But as its pilot activated the propane burner, I was jolted awake by the sharp, sudden rush of burning gas, repeated in tight explosions, peppering the quiet morning with panic. The balloon rose, as did my heart rate. Disoriented, half-awake, I felt a sense of invasion. I'd known about the balloons; I just thought I could enjoy or ignore them on my own terms. As the amused pilot waved to me as I blinked up at him from my bed, I suddenly felt differently about what it meant to be a citizen of Springville.

Such is the dawning of the digital age for students and teachers of literature. For quite some time, electronic reading and writing has been arriving, moving in like a fleet of hot air balloons quietly filling the sky of our literary world: word processing, research databases, text archives, web searches, etc. These have had a certain novelty factor, but electronic ways to read, research, and write have not been seen as particularly game-changing. They have provided convenience, mostly. The odd experiment with hypertext Hamlet or multimedia Milton has been a mere curiosity, nothing to alter standard practices. We have gone on reading our printed books and writing our printed papers as though everything about books and writing wasn't suddenly about to change.

In the new century has come a grand disruption to the state of literary studies, jolting us awake to a brave new world to which we must all quickly reorient how we think and what we do about books. If teachers and students of writing and literature are not yet rubbing their eyes with a mixture of terror and awe, they soon will be. Literacy is being radically redefined.

Of course, literacy has always been radically disruptive. Those who can cipher and compose are in a position of independence and potential action with far-reaching consequences. This is why democratic states have championed literacy and repressive regimes have burned books and authors. The consequences of literacy (or illiteracy) spread broadly across society, influencing politics, business, the arts, religion, family life, and the life of the mind in general.

But literacy is not always the same creature. It is mediated by its own tools: wax or clay tablets, papyrus, vellum, paper books, printed books, eBooks; a stylus, a quill, a typewriter, a keyboard, a monitor, an iPad—every way of writing or reading carries with it symbolic systems, technological requirements, social conventions, and patterns of thought and behavior. This is something easy to forget when a certain medium for literacy (print) has been dominant for centuries.

When printing came, literacy became disruptive on a scale never before seen. The Protestant Reformation, as Martin Luther confirmed, would have been impossible without a printed Bible—or the reach of those printed tracts that energized religious change in 16th century Europe. Modern democracy was born in Enlightenment literary practices, including a more popularized press and the greater sense of citizen participation that came with it. Are we to expect that electronic reading and writing will not be similarly disruptive?

As Paolo Freire has observed, when people become literate, they are “no longer satisfied to watch, they want to participate” (13). But the terms of participation change when the medium of literacy changes. Web 2.0, often called the “participatory web,” names a set of communication tools and practices that foreground interaction and creativity on a scale so far beyond the scope of print publishing that we have to recalibrate our very notions of literacy and of literature.

A more participatory literacy is rewriting the rules of who gets to have say and sway. This will be as true in the fields of literature, education, and writing as it has already proven to be in journalism. The citizen journalist is empowered to tweet, blog, and interact with the ideas and the main players on the stage of world events. The literary student is also enfranchised today as never before. He or she can find, search, interact with, create, and manipulate literary texts as never before, applying these actions with equal ease to public or personal purposes. And discussion about books today has broken the door off the hinges of traditional literary criticism. Readers find fellow readers across the planet as easily as across the room, authors and readers connect, and literature lives independently of professional critics, publishers, academic scholars, or even teachers. There is enormous freedom to author stories and develop interested audiences or to influence the worlds of reading and writing through reviews and self-published criticism.

All of this will disrupt the traditional academic approach to literature. We now consume literature differently, connect to it differently, and create responses to it differently. And so, anticipating the coming changes, we boldly bypassed the traditional literary essay and research paper, embraced the disruptive literacy of our new media, and this eBook is the outcome of that experiment. We blogged, and we researched, and we interacted among ourselves and with people across the globe, and in the space of a few weeks, this eBook has taken shape.

Our book is divided into five parts

In Part 1: Disrupting Literary Writing, Samuel McGrath introduces departures from traditional literary study. He uses Douglas Adams's genre-defying *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* as a model for understanding our new literary modes of consuming, connecting, and creating. Using Herman Melville's *Moby Dick*, Gideon Burton advocates literary blogging as a replacement for the traditional research paper. In turn, Ben Wagner draws upon F. Scott Fitzgerald's *The Great Gatsby* to define a need for evolved literary criticism in the digital age, and Ashley Nelson lays out the groundwork for different sorts of secondary sources today, as illustrated in her experience researching James Joyce's *Dubliners*.

In Part 2: Foregrounding Author Identity, Aly Rutter and Andrea Ostler use opposing examples (Harper Lee and Toni Morrison) to illustrate the differences, and the stakes, when authors either dodge or embrace public identity.

In Part 3: (Dis)connecting in the Digital Age, the troubling issues of identity, anonymity, and isolation incidental to online culture are addressed. First, Ariel Letts uses Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* to raise the issue of constructing artificial personas in online discussions; then Nyssa Silvester addresses the problem of online echo chambers by applying Fyodor Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* to internet culture. James Matthews sees Henry David Thoreau's *Walden* as a bold challenge to the artifice and hyperconnectivity of the online world. Obviously, literature can both illustrate and call into question the terms of our new digital environment.

In Part 4: Reading Digital Culture through Literature, Derrick Clements uses *Assassins*, the musical by Stephen Sondheim and John Weidman, as a lens for understanding contemporary "information entitlement." Taylor Gilbert's fresh imitation of C. S. Lewis's *Screwtape Letters* uses the diabolical perspective to satirize those ignorant of digital literacy. In "Serious Simulation," Matt Harrison finds in Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* and its *Battle School* an analogy to the "in beta" state of online media. And the fanciful fiction of Jorge Luis Borges, Rachael Schiel explains, prefigured the internet's fluid realities.

In Part 5: Transforming Literary Learning, E. B. White's *Charlotte's Web* becomes the way Carlie Wallentine makes us question just what a primary text is in the multimedia present. Text alone, it seems, is insufficient for learning literature today. Amy Whitaker makes a case for using visual

imagery in teaching Wilson Rawls' *Where the Red Fern Grows*, and Ashley Lewis claims (through Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre*) that literary learning today is necessarily social. Bri Zabriskie takes that point a step further, using Mark Twain's *Huckleberry Finn* to describe how reading and research are now socialized in the digital age.

All of our writing falls under a Creative Commons license, meaning that we encourage the reuse and repurposing of our content provided simple attribution is given. We hope you will feel free to sample, respond, interact, and carry forward from where we've gone. It has taken courage for us to dive in, to participate, when it is so easy to be self-doubting or to hold back. I'm glad we haven't. We hope you won't.

Chapter 1

Breaking Conventions: A Hitchhiker's Guide to Scholarly Research in a Digital Environment

by Samuel McGrath

Introduction

On May 25, 2011, NPR reported about PayPal co-founder Peter Thiel and his controversial plan to pay twenty-four teenagers \$100,000 fellowships to drop out of college for two years and start their own companies. Thiel believes that the modern education system reacts too slowly to change and stifles innovative thinking (Peralta). When I read this article, I must admit that I wasn't surprised, as these are accusations I am hearing more often about public education. In his wonderful speech "Changing Education Paradigms," Sir Ken Robinson, PhD, a renowned education expert, also addresses the state of free thinking and innovation in our antiquated educational paradigm. He asks a question I feel has yet to be answered completely: How do you keep education legitimate while encouraging creativity and innovation? At Brigham Young University, our Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class has been exploring this same question in terms of scholarly writing.

Writing in the digital age requires us to break the conventions of scholarly writing by using online tools to enhance traditional research.

On the first day of class, many of us were shocked to learn the parameters of our new writing course. There would be no traditional papers, no secluded, private writing that only our professor Dr. Burton would read; instead, we would blog. We would cast our research and ideas into the web where anybody could read them, including our classmates. Our tools for this class would be the internet itself. As a class, our focus would be how we consume, connect, and create, combining social discovery and human filters with traditional libraries to help us research our book of choice and to write

meaningful criticism on our blogs. Oh yes, and we would blog our actual research process as well. Yikes! We would be breaking scholarly conventions that had been drilled into us during our time at college. These sources weren't going to be peer-reviewed. Could our writing be of any worth if our sources hadn't been in a scholarly journal? Worst of all, our writing was going to be available for anyone to read? This was new ground for all of us.

A Nonconventional Example

Douglas Adams, author of *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*, is an expert at breaking conventions. When the book that defined his career was published in 1979, it was an instant success, and its popularity spread across the world. In *Hitchhiker's Guide*, Arthur Dent, a bumbling, clueless, earth man finds himself cast away into space with no home after the Earth was destroyed in order to construct a hyperspace bypass. As Dent explores the universe with his alien friend, Ford Prefect, the reader discovers just how nonsensical and random the universe really is. Professor Shlomo Maital, a senior research fellow at the Technion Institute of Management, praises Adams in his blog, TIMnovate, for his ability to break conventions and serve as inspiration for other innovators. Adams's success can be measured by the fact that these stories have been adapted for radio, book, audiobook, TV, film, and even theater. His skill shines in all formats, and his fans all over the internet agree that no one can successfully imitate the way he writes. The key to Adams's success is the way he breaks the unspoken conventions of science fiction while showing an understanding and appreciation for those same rules. Adams tips his hat to the same conventions he laughs at, and we as readers are in on the joke. The result is an unforgettable galactic comedy.

Marvin the Paranoid Android, my favorite character in the book, meets these conventions while breaking them. After reading blogs and fansites, I've seen that I'm not the only one who loves Marvin's character. A chronically depressed robot who can't stand humans or other robots and constantly complains, "Life, don't talk to me about life" (Adams 63)—who wouldn't laugh? We find value in Marvin as a comical character because he meets one important convention of science fiction: the android.

Most science fiction includes androids in some way. Quite often these androids are super-intelligent, and are learning to deal with human experiences. Data from *Star Trek: The Next Generation* is one popular example of an android learning to deal with basic emotions. Classic examples

in literature are Asimov's Robot series, beginning with *I Robot*, and Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* All of these address the issue of combining robot intelligence with human characteristics, especially emotion.

We love Marvin because he fits our expectations for androids. Marvin has the largest "brain" in the galaxy and calculates complicated problems lightning-fast—when he feels up to it. Adams breaks conventions by parodying the typical android and showing what the most pathetic of human emotions would look like in a robot. We, the readers, like this device because we see ourselves in Marvin and recognize the irony of a super-intelligent yet emotionally unstable robot. Carl R. Kropf says in the journal *Science Fiction Studies* that Adams's reversal of conventions comments "on the bankruptcy of the genre's paradigms and rais[es] questions about the nature and the function of the genre" (62). Our writing class, by breaking conventions of scholarly writing, is also raising questions about the nature and function of the scholarly genre and how it should evolve in the digital age.

The Big Question

Breaking conventions can be a risky business if writers want their work to be taken seriously, especially when dealing with long-standing traditions like the science fiction genre or scholarly research and writing. It is, if I may be permitted to mix metaphors, like walking a tightrope suspended over thin ice. One misstep and you fall through. If we move too far away from the conventions, we run the risk of not being taken seriously or appearing to be careless in our craft. On the other hand, playing it too safe compromises our initial purpose of creating something fresh. To successfully break conventions, we must show a mastery of those same rules we are breaking. Adams did this perfectly in his writing. There is no doubt his jokes are carefully crafted to address convention and turn it on its head. Because he met his readers' expectations, he was able to bend the rules with greater impunity. Nevertheless, Adams's books are not often seen as literature worth studying in schools or scholarly journals. The question remains: How do we break conventions while creating something that can be taken seriously as scholarly research and writing?

The Process

Consume:

Written in 1978, *Hitchhiker* broke the conventions of the consumption of information with the idea of an electronic book that stored millions of books' worth of information in a small, handheld device. "The reason why it was published in the form of a micro sub meson electronic component is... [it] would require several inconveniently large buildings to carry it around in" (Adams 20). Providing monumental amounts of information literally at Arthur Dent's fingertips, the Guide was a prophetic vision of eBooks and online encyclopedias such as Wikipedia.

Writing and reading in the digital age involves new methods of consumption as well. How we consume both books and information as we research is changing. In our class we were encouraged to experience at least one of our readings in a nontraditional format, just to see the benefits and drawbacks of each medium. Matt Harrison has been looking at the comic book version of *Ender's Game*, considering the role of comic books as literature. Carlie Wallentine and I have been experiencing our books in many formats, including text, audio, and film. The experience of different formats has been beneficial to me as I have been looking at Adams's humor; each format led me to consider how humor works in different mediums and how Adams has created humor by breaking the conventions of his genre.

Our consumption of research information has also changed with this class. In her research on *Where the Red Fern Grows*, Amy Whitaker has used art to explore how it can enhance the study of literature, as has Rachael Schiel while studying Borges. Ben Wagner has used Twitter to research and find what people are saying about *The Great Gatsby*. Scholarly journals are not the only places where people are writing about literature. The digital world offers many other ways to consume literature and information. It can be surprising to see how many people care and write meaningful things about the books we have chosen to study.

Connect:

Adams also broke conventions in order to connect poor Arthur Dent with other characters and the information he needed. Imagine how much more lost he would have been without his Babel Fish. The Babel Fish is essentially a plot device that allows Arthur to understand any alien language spoken to him. The fact that translation is performed by a small, telepathic, parasitic fish breaks a major convention of science fiction by downplaying the role of

science and giving an important role to nature. Our class did not have access to any Babel Fish to help us in our research, but we found tools online that allowed us to connect to people and information impossible to find in a traditional library.

Connecting as a class in the digital world has enriched our research. For instance, we have used social bookmarking (Diigo, in our case) to share discoveries with our classmates as we come across resources or ideas online that deal with our topics of study,

We have also been encouraged to use social networking and other tools to connect with people who have emotional stock in the books we are studying. This has led to meaningful, direct communication with people with insight to contribute. Annie Ostler has talked in class about the value she has found in fansites and forums where African Americans have talked about their responses to and perspectives on Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon*. This outreach has been an invaluable resource to her because it offers a perspective that she could otherwise never experience, a perspective extremely valuable while studying a Toni Morrison novel. We benefit from people who are invested in our books and have spent time reading and thinking about them. The results aren't always a golden nugget of information, but they have often proved enlightening.

Create:

Douglas Adams rewrote the *Hitchhiker* stories numerous times, creating radio, TV, movie, book, and play versions. It's interesting that with each rewrite, Adams changed the story slightly to better fit the new medium. In the same way, we must slightly change our research and writing when we use different media to explore our works of literature. Blogging, and the internet in general, gives us an outlet to explore different ways of experiencing a text and then writing about it.

Derrick Clements took the music from Stephen Sondheim's musical *Assassins* and played it on the piano while singing the lyrics to get a better appreciation of the work as a whole. This is something that usually would not occur to a student doing traditional research, but because we are documenting our research on our blogs, this experience can benefit both Derrick and his readers in their understanding of the musical.

The rewriting of valued literature is nothing new, but the digital world offers new opportunities to create remixes of others' work. Ashley Nelson

has blogged about her experiences with fan fiction and its benefits in literary study. To write fan fiction, Ashley needs a good understanding of the work she is imitating. This need encourages analysis of character, themes, plot structure, and many other elements of the story. Creation of new media has turned out to be an excellent way to engage a text and learn more from it.

Conclusion

Like Douglas Adams, we have found ourselves breaking the conventions of traditional literary criticism in order to push the genre forward and open it up to a different standard, one which values social discovery, online tools, and research documentation as an essential part of the process we call academic writing. In this eBook, *Writing about Literature in the Digital Age*, we discuss our methods and discoveries as we have asked ourselves the big question, How can we create legitimate scholarship while using the tools of the twenty-first century?

About the Author

Samuel McGrath is an English teaching major at Brigham Young University. He considers himself an amateur technophile and an avid lover of books and literature. See Samuel's blog at <http://sammcgrathwritings.blogspot.com/>.

Chapter 2

Chasing the White Whale of Literary Blogging

by Gideon Burton

“There are some enterprises in which a careful disorderliness is the true method.”

—Herman Melville, *Moby Dick*

I am on a quest to change how students write about literature in the digital age and how we who teach them may guide that process. Here is my claim: Students of literature should set aside the standard research paper and use blogging as their main means for writing and research.

You don’t know how hard it was for me to say that.

You see, for two decades I have taught the genres and standards of formal academic writing. Casting off from the secure moorings provided by the research paper genre creates an anxious mix of feelings. When instructing my students, “Your blog will be the primary method and evidence of your literary research and writing,” I have felt a bit like Captain Ahab — on some foolhardy, monomaniacal quest, dragging along my student crews into a watery grave. Sometimes I have felt like Ishmael, Melville’s narrator — by turns amused, reflective, endangered, but surviving enough to document a breathtaking adventure. And sometimes I have felt like Herman Melville, whose literary experiment wasn’t vindicated until long after his career failed and he died.

Yet I stick to my claim, nailing it to the mast like Ahab’s gold doubloon. Our literature students would do far better to blog than to write a research paper. This is in part due to the merits of the new medium, and in part due to the sudden inadequacy of the research paper.

Blogging has many faults, and remains in flux like all digital genres. It is not a perfect medium for literary inquiry and criticism, to be sure. Nor do I

mean to claim that writing a traditional research paper on a literary topic is without merit. But the imperfections of the newer medium are less problematic than continuing with the old. It is time for people who are serious about literature to transition to a more viable approach to writing about it in the digital age.

This chapter is meant to whet the reader's interest in both the virtues of blogging and the limits of traditional literary criticism, but it is neither a full outline of blogging pedagogy, nor a scholarly treatment of the research paper as an enfeebled genre. Like my students, through blogging I have learned that tentative and provisional writing has great value — especially when put into circulation without delay. This is one of the virtues of digital writing. What is timely and shared may have as much or more value as what is put into a more finished and perfected form — in part because it can lead more efficiently to more formal treatment by inviting interest and involving readers early to be critics or even collaborators.

Literature in the Open Sea of New Media

The call to blog is like a call to sea, to that ocean of new media that swells around us with its electric allure. The fluidity of electronic texts fairly begs for seafaring metaphors. We've all been surfing for awhile, but what lies deeper in the currents? Taking leave of the shore, my students and I have become cybernauts, active explorer-researchers, each of our blogs a kind of ship's log.

I have asked students to course their way through their chosen primary texts, sounding out their depths in standard and more novel ways; I have asked them to ply their way through the more charted databases of conventional literary scholarship, but also to sail up the Amazon of Amazon.com, with its user reviews and recommendation engines; I have asked them to trawl the tidewaters of alternate book formats; I have urged them to post book reviews to social book sites like Goodreads. We have taken our blogs and our love of literature out onto the open sea of new media.

It turns out that literary works prove more than useful in cyberspace. Their structure and notoriety make them anchors, or at least stable vantage points, islands in the flux and flow of new media. Literature has always been a landing place, a haven. Perhaps it is also a ship, like the Pequod, which "sharply bowed to the blast, and gored the dark waves in her madness, till, like showers of silver chips, the foam-flakes flew over her bulwarks"

(Melville, 232). Literature presses artfully through the storms of history and culture, and I must say it has been a thing of beauty to witness my students use Joyce, Borges, or Toni Morrison to carve sea lanes in the maelstrom of media culture.

Fragmentation and Distraction

I love great works of literature because of their ability to read us, to make a map of the present and renew their relevance for each generation, including our digital age. Moby Dick has been working that way for me. For example, in the copious “Extracts” section preceding the first chapter of Moby Dick, Melville presents a long miscellany of quotations about whales that give amplitude to his subject, but not coherently. This pre-chapter is a kind of 19th century Google search results page: thematic continuity but logical fragmentation.

Does Melville’s “Extracts” prefigure the cognitive impairment of the the Net Generation? Alas, to my dismay I have found some students can latch onto a theme in their blogs and play with it, yet never really develop it. Rather than being an instrument of sustained thought, their blog seems to be a way of suspending or deferring real thinking. In teaching blogging, have I encouraged evasion over persuasion, a lack of critical discernment? Have I given them an academic pass into the free-for-all of superficial pop culture?

Fragmentation and distraction are the chief pathologies diagnosed by critics of the digital age like Nicholas Carr. “Calm, focused, undistracted, the linear mind is being pushed aside by a new kind of mind that wants and needs to take in and dole out information in short, disjointed, often overlapping bursts — the faster, the better” (Carr, 10). Carr updates Neil Postman’s pre-internet indictment of our devolved attention spans through electronic media (see *Amusing Ourselves to Death*, especially chapter 4, “The Typographic Mind”).

Literary culture seems inherently incompatible with how information is experienced online, at least for some: “[I]t is alarmingly easy to slide into a slipstream,” said Sven Birkerts, in a 2007 editorial about the literary blogosphere, “or, better, go rollicking in a snake-bed of sites and posts, where each twist of text catches hold of another’s tail, the whole progress and regress morphing into a no-exit situation that has to be something new under the sun.” The blogosphere may be exciting, he concludes, but “it is too fluid in its nature ever to focus our widely diverging cultural energies. A hopscotch

through the referential enormity of argument and opinion cannot settle the ground under our feet.”

In some ways the intertext is the great unweaving, the Untext, replacing the coherence found in narratives or logical persuasion with a kind of cultural attention deficit disorder. This seems hardly the fertile ground in which things literary can thrive. The study of literature, the processes of reading it, researching it, writing about it — these are activities that reinscribe our faith in order, in meaning, in the clarity of cause and effect, in the efficacy of analysis, in the structured flow of reasoned argument. Perhaps, instead of rejecting conventional literary criticism, this is the time to hold fast to it.

Defending Traditional Writing about Literature

In chapter 44 of *Moby Dick*, “The Chart,” Captain Ahab is shown pondering over his charts. “Almost every night they were brought out; almost every night some pencil marks were effaced, and others were substituted. For with the charts of all four oceans before him, Ahab was threading a maze of currents and eddies.” We writing teachers assign literary analysis so that students will thread the mazes of texts, engaging them critically, and we assign research so they will seek out and synthesize sources, drawing them meaningfully together through an organizing purpose. Ahab had his whale to chase; students have their thesis statement.

As an English professor I have assigned and read thousands of research papers over the years, and as someone trained specially in writing and rhetoric, I have come to respect and deeply value how thought can be developed and communicated coherently and intelligibly by way of 10-20 pages of argument and analysis, supported by appropriate outside sources.

The traditional research paper is intended to immerse students in the sort of disciplined thinking that long-form writing can require, and to engage students with the larger world of ideas through careful reading and research in a given field. In finding scholarly sources, evaluating them, then appropriately incorporating them into their own arguments, students learn critical thinking — a quality needed in ever greater supply today.

In *Moby Dick*, Ishmael describes “fast fish” and “loose fish” (chapter 89). Melville’s novel as a whole seems to be the storyteller’s effort to fasten his fish, to pin down his experience, to assert control and meaning over the sprawling details of the whaling odyssey. In his efforts to make sense of things, Ishmael compares to the traditional student of literature, launched

upon the inscrutable oceans of artistic prose, the bewildering array of scholarly criticism, and now, the paralyzing abundance of online information.

Ishmael fights back against the chaos through reasoned analysis and the gathering and synthesizing of secondary sources. In chapter 32, “Cetology,” Ishmael analyzes “what the best and latest authorities have laid down” about whales in an effort to create “some systematized exhibition of the whale in his broad genera” (Melville, 129). I find it interesting that he uses book formats (The “folio” whale, the “octavo” whale, the “duodecimo” whale, etc.) as a classification system. Both in the sources he consults (published authors) and in the abstract schema he uses for analysis, the printed book becomes the sense-making mechanism for his vast subject.

Ishmael models to us the print paradigm, with its faith in comprehension linked directly to the scrutability and familiarity of the paragon format for print. Ishmael will “write the book” on whaling. All the permutations of whale folklore and science can be wrangled into order if the right books are consulted, abstracted, and cited. Though in briefer form, this is essentially what we teachers of literature have set our students to doing with their researched essays. Using the harpoon of a thesis statement and the sturdy lines of literary analysis and scholarly research, they can spear the whale of their intellectual quest, lashing it fast to comprehension, reducing it to the order and authority of printed matter.

Only, it doesn’t work — not for Ishmael, and not for our students. Long before networked computing was ever conceived of, Melville (and Ishmael) were fighting the same information war as did Denis Diderot and the encyclopédistes a century before *Moby Dick*. How to find an order to the new abundance of information?

Moby Dick is as much a critique of this effort as it is a result of it. Throughout its hundreds of pages a tsunami of sources are brought to bear in a journey of understanding that ultimately founders. The “Cetology” chapter is a microcosm of the whole: Ishmael’s confidence in both his sources and his classification system are high, but by chapter’s end, the scheme breaks down, and Ishmael abandons his tight, encyclopedic organization. His fast fish has gone loose. “God keep me from ever completing anything,” Ishmael exclaims, either complaining or rejoicing. “This whole book is but a draught — nay, but the draught of a draught. Oh Time, Strength, Cash, and Patience!” Was his explanation breakdown, or breakthrough?

Blogging to Safety

“Your whole blog is but a draft — nay, but the draft of a draft.”

I think I have been paraphrasing Ishmael, drilling into my students the virtues of a more casual mode of writing. It is okay to explore, to be tentative. It is okay to launch out with an interpretive scheme (like Melville’s amateur cetologist) and to find it unworkable. This is part of a valuable process, a process you must document.

Perhaps the white whale of traditional literary criticism is the false security of a finished argument. The principal benefit I have observed in asking students to blog has been removing the stigma of meaning making from the activity of writing — or at least, unshackling students from the feeling that if they are not making some formal, reasoned, well-supported, logically sound argument, then they have nothing to say.

The informality of blogging is its genius. When writing isn’t precious, rare, and elevated, it has a better chance of being frequent, authentic, and (in the aggregate), copious. So I assign my students not to write about works of literature twice a semester, but once a day. And while I do guide them to the most productive kinds of posting, I emphasize frequency, brevity, and personal interest rather than length, depth, or coherence among their posts. Here are the benefits from a year’s efforts of using blogging in the literature classroom.

Blogging Benefit: Writing More

Blogging gives students a comfort level, a habit — even an identity as a writer. And while not every student continues to blog following my course, many do, and I am unaware of any students (even those advancing to graduate school) who spontaneously or regularly write research papers. Investing in student blogging yields a more sustainable literacy.

More immediately, a student’s accumulated blog posts create an ample supply of less developed ideas that can readily become more developed: informality can lead to formality as an earlier post is built upon to become a better, later one, or as multiple posts are combined and revised into a more formal literary argument. Students find they have more to draw from, especially when the social element is factored in: they are more likely to be interested in developing thoughts that have generated even modest responses.

Blogging Benefit: Process over Product

Blogging encourages students to become process- rather than product-oriented. The many tentative, informal, largely uncoordinated posts that make up a student literary blog end up documenting a process that proves as valuable as a more formal academic product. Was Ishmael's cetology a failure? Yes, in itself, but not at all when seen as the documentation of a process.

One can read many of the chapters of *Moby Dick* as Melville's varied experiments in sense-making: What if the whale subject were investigated in terms of anatomy? (chapter 86, "The Tail"). What if in terms of visual images? (chapter 40, "Of the Monstrous Pictures of Whales"). What if in terms of cuisine? (chapter 15, "Chowder"; chapter 64, "Stubb's Supper"; chapter 65, "The Whale as a Dish"), or the people involved? (chapters 26-27, "Knights and Squires"; chapter 28, "Ahab"). My students' posts are often this way — a set of experiments upon a text or upon a theme. These posts lack sequential coherence, but they build thematically, and more importantly, they construct in the student the sense that they are taking charge of and pleasure in their subject

When students are process-oriented, they are more flexible in their approach, and more critical of their own methods. Rather than hewing to the set standards of a formal academic genre, they are charged with the task of accounting for their own thinking. This licenses them to play, but makes that playfulness serious. It gives them permission to fail, providing them at once the means to redeem those failures. So long as they keep the narrative going of their experiments, those experiments will be seen as such, and will have discernible, if unpredictable, results.

Blogging Benefit: The Power of the Personal

Students take ownership of personal blogs in ways impossible within more traditional academic genres. They do not conceptualize blogs as instruments of thought; they experience them as expressions of personality. This comes with risks, as students often lack discretion in how they manifest their identities, but for me the greater risk is in stifling the personal or ignoring the power it unleashes.

Blogging transforms writing into multimedia creativity. Students design the header, the background image, the side content, the colors and fonts. They add widgets that are part functional and part decorative. They post an

image and biographical blurb in an “About Me” section, or include links to online slideshows, virtual bookshelves, or to their other projects and online social networks. A blog is packed with possibility for personal expression, for self-representation.

Within such a persona-creative context, writing about literature can become a far more living thing. It is connected not just to an assignment, nor to a period of academic schooling, nor to a particular semester, nor to a particular book. It is connected to their lives and to their evolving identities.

When people ask me to explain my love for Moby Dick, I answer with a single word, “Ishmael.” It isn’t a book about a crazy captain or a white whale. Moby Dick is a voice — an animate, fascinating, multi-faceted, entertaining tale-teller. His persona is the coherence that ties the wildly divergent components of Melville’s magnum opus together.

Centering meaning within the personality of a narrator — this is the genius of blogging. Yes, I do encourage my students to push beyond the idiosyncrasies and superficialities of their casual entries — but not before affirming the value and coherence of all their blogging insofar as their posting is indeed personal. Their lives bring coherence to their writing, if they allow themselves to be present in this way.

This is not my way of subverting the merits of rational discourse, or substituting a kind of touchy-feely personal creativity for the heavy lifting of solid analysis. Quite the contrary. My claim is that the rigorous researching and analyzing that we teachers of literature have prized is more likely to happen by way of the personal rather than by effacing the student’s life or voice.

Logos, pathos, and ethos are the three rhetorical appeals of writing: persuasion comes about through reasoning and subject matter (logos); through emotion (pathos); and through the credibility of the author (ethos). Traditional academic writing foregrounds the first of these, plays down the second, and actively effaces the third. If literary arguments are to be taken seriously, the reasoning goes, then pretty much everything but the reasoning must go. Student writing is to be serious, not passionate. And credible arguments are threatened by reference to individual taste or experience. The pronoun “I” is banished from conventional literary criticism.

This is where traditional and online writing are at odds. Online writing is not just more casual, it is more personal. When students try to sound academic online, the life goes out of their writing and their audiences click

away; when students play to their own passions and interests, not only do their audiences respond better, but so do they.

You may not care about *Moby Dick*, but you know that I do. It isn't Melville's genius that is giving me this way to talk through my subject; it is my own passionate interest in the text. Students become better critics of texts when they are invested in them, and blogging gives them a ready instrument to express and expand that interest. I have had more fun (and more practical benefit) from *Moby Dick* since I began blogging about my favorite novel. My students are finding that their interest in literature expands as they play to the personal. This generates energy both in and beyond the classroom. The personal aspect of literary blogging provides a renewable source of motivation.

Blogging Benefit: Social Literacy

That personal aspect is linked tightly to another benefit within this medium, a social literacy that blogging makes both possible and attractive. I mean "social literacy" in two senses: new media are in general social media; and blogging about literature has social benefits.

"And I only am escaped alone to tell thee," begins the epilogue to *Moby Dick*, with Ishmael quoting Job. The dramatic and tragic conclusion of this whaling story is summed up in this poignant phrase and in the image of poor Ishmael surviving the shipwreck, floating on a coffin. However, Ishmael's loneliness is not existential or desperate; his story is richly meaningful precisely because he tells it. Meaning is achieved through sharing; communion through communication. The greater tragedy would have been his silence.

There is much that is superficial and even dangerous about the hyperconnected, socially mediated world of the present. Much is to be evolved in how social media will be part of education or part of our lives. The social mores are very much a work in progress. But despite the gaffes and gambles of our social media, there is little prospect of retreating from them, and every reason to refine and perfect them.

What the social media have done, in just a few short years, has been to evolve practices of sharing that are rapid, frequent, and persistent. Because I can tell you what I ate for breakfast, I will do so. Because I can post a picture and distribute this to friends any time, I will do so. This flourishing of sharing and content has introduced problems and challenges. But our worries about

these media should not blind us to the power they have unleashed: shared knowledge is more powerful than private knowledge; and knowledge that is rapidly distributed, even if casual or imperfect, can prove as consequential as older, more formal kinds.

The social media have also raised expectations more generally about keeping up on what one another is doing. When most people are now increasingly fluent in the quotidian activities of their peers and neighbors, opting out of this social literacy becomes not merely a social gaffe, but an intellectual blunder. As I have argued elsewhere (in my blog, AcademicEvolution.com), we do not have the luxury of remaining in a print paradigm world in which knowledge is paced, formatted, and controlled by traditional academic and publishing institutions. The genie is out of the bottle, and from here on out the world of knowledge will be primarily digital, and it will be optimized for social media.

Blogging Benefit: Collaboration

Despite the lonely picture of Ishmael at the close of *Moby Dick*, throughout the story he takes us almost lovingly into the complex society of the Pequod and all its quirky characters. At moments like a competition with a German whaler, Melville depicts a kind of joyous animation in the Pequod crew's joint action: Starbuck, Stubb, and Flask coordinate the race to the whale, while boatmen pull oars and a triad of harpooners guarantee the Pequod's victory over the *Jungfrau*. It is Ahab's isolation that makes of him such a pitiful creature, his only relationship being his warped passion for the white whale.

Not to press the analogy too far, but the isolated literary critic can be compared to Ahab, a kind of gothic figure, focused on his prize, but perhaps warped in the process, untempered by human interaction. The making of literary meaning need not — should not — be conducted in isolation in the 21st century. Ahab insisted upon his solitary quest, and it was his undoing. Holding to a pattern of individual literary inquiry today may be equally treacherous.

Today, the social practices of new media are creating a “culture of sharing,” often manifest through remixes and mashups, creative combinations of media that are rapidly produced, disseminated, and repurposed online. The concept of a public domain and the advent of Creative Commons licensing are pushing past the barriers of copyright and intellectual property protection,

changing the default expectation from “don’t touch what I’ve made” to “use my stuff and I’ll use yours.” In short, people want to exchange their ideas and media in a fluid, creative environment.

Remixing and media sharing are currently mostly associated with popular culture and entertainment media. Only a few frontrunners, like Henry Jenkins or Lawrence Lessig, are looking seriously at remix culture within academia. But the Open Culture movement is gaining steam, and open education resources (OER), along with Open Access publishing, will be reconfiguring the use and reuse of texts and media in education. Just because the culture of sharing has not reached the Publication of the Modern Language Association doesn’t mean a more interactive and collaborative approach to literary studies is not the present future.

While it is possible for students to blog in isolation (the dreaded “monoblogue”), the culture of sharing tends toward notifying one’s friends about posts, inviting their feedback, and even their cooperation. Collaboration is not a necessary component to blogging, but a natural extension of it. I require my students to comment upon one another’s blog posts, and I also require them to research on one another’s topics and contribute bibliography and insights for projects other than their own. In more than one instance, I have seen a student, disheartened by her subject not going anywhere, suddenly reanimated into pursuing it because someone else provided a comment, or a suggested source.

Social bookmarking, though not a necessary component of blogging, can be integrated with it. My students all have diigo accounts, and use this bookmarking tool both to track their own interests and to publish items of common interest to a public bookmarking group. These shared bookmarks appear within a widget on the side of their blogs. Suddenly, they are not the lone researcher or reader; they are inviting and providing comments and resources that benefit a group.

This eBook represents collaboration on a grander and more formal scale. Conditioned to sharing comments and bookmarks with one another, my students have become interested in and invested in one another’s projects. Within a very short time, we have worked together in teams to produce a more finished project that is greater than the sum of its parts. The chapters in this volume do not have the length or finish of a set of traditional research papers or academic articles. But they demonstrate the vitality of collaborative literary inquiry, and our little eBook remains a permanent and accessible

knowledge commodity that can be built upon individually or by others.

Most students concluding a college course in literature or writing demonstrate their literary expertise through a private researching effort in which they need not speak with another human being either in the process of their research or in its final product. My students will no longer be satisfied with creating a research paper made for an audience of one, not perfected in the crucible of social exchange (except, perhaps, for a perfunctory peer review of a final draft), and never shared with the world. And I believe this dissatisfaction to be a very good thing.

Conclusion

We teachers of literature and writing cannot afford not to be in the game of new media, creating and sharing in ways more informal, rapid, and collaborative than the guardians of literacy have found acceptable in the past. Not if we wish to stay relevant. The nearly ubiquitous, networked, socially mediated online environment in which students live, breathe, and have their being is changing how, what, and why they read, how they respond to books, and how they develop and share opinions.

Pretty much every aspect of reading, analysis, research, drafting, writing, and publishing is no longer what it was when print was the default intellectual medium. In but a few years' time the digital environment has set up expectations for communication from which there is no retreat, despite the routine lambasting that punsters give to new media. Yet, the standard research paper stands aloof, unaware of and largely unresponsive to these complex changes in thinking and communicating. When the high point of engaging the online world is merely judging the quality of internet sites or citing them properly, then literary studies are at a low point in the digital culture that is now dominant.

I will go so far as to say that teachers of writing who persist in training students to write in ways that ignore this context are endangering the literacy of their students. Rather than preparing them to communicate well within society, they actually prevent them from doing so at a time when it is both practical and profitable to interact with others. Print-based literacy assumes student competency is only ever provisional and preparatory, something one practices in isolation to develop a competency, but not through actual engagement with humans or action on authentic tasks. If teachers of writing condition students to believe that the formation of their thoughts must be

done in isolation, or that research is not collaborative, or that publishing is the privilege of an elect few who have their work validated only in formal, time-consuming ways generally unavailable — then they are effectively disabling students, keeping them from the competencies they most need in today's communication contexts, and from the joys of literature's relevance to the rising generation.

About the Author

Gideon Burton is Assistant Professor of English at Brigham Young University where he teaches rhetoric, writing, literature, and new media. His academic ePublications include *Silva Rhetoricae: The Forest of Rhetoric* (<http://rhetoric.byu.edu>); the Mormon Literature & Creative Arts database (<http://mormonlit.lib.byu.edu>); and *Academic Evolution* (<http://AcademicEvolution.com>). He has integrated blogging into the teaching of advanced writing, documenting his and his students' work at *The Digital Writer* (<http://thedigitalwriter.blogspot.com>).

Chapter 3

Not the Same Old Sport: The Need for an Evolutionary Step in Literary Criticism in the Digital Age

by Ben Wagner

“The intimate revelations of young men or at least the terms in which they express them are usually plagiaristic and marred by obvious suppression”
(Fitzgerald 6).

Presentation of the Problem

If literary criticism is to survive in this digital age, it must adapt to become something new, different, and more intimately personal. The old academic paradigm of literary criticism is based upon a print model and makes certain assumptions about its readers, assumptions that need to be reworked in the digital age. I came across this problem recently while reading and researching *The Great Gatsby* for my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class. When I first read this book in 2003, race was not a topic of discussion in my high school English class. Then again, I did go to a predominantly white high school in rural South Carolina, so race wasn't exactly a popular topic of conversation. But as I reread the novel, I found myself noting the frequent allusions to race relations.

Because I had never heard the book be analyzed from this perspective, I thought that perhaps I had come across a new, or at least relatively rare, angle from which to analyze and deconstruct the novel. I was wrong. When I began searching the library databases for literary criticism about this issue, I found that it was not in short supply. Not only was there plenty of scholarly work about this topic but there was plenty of scholarly work about the issue of race in *The Great Gatsby* written in every decade since the book's publication.

This has proven to be a problem for me—frankly, it’s hard to find an original angle or interpretation when there is already so much scholarly work on an issue. This forced me to confront a larger problem that we have to deal with as academics in the digital age; since their publication, many of these canonical works have been analyzed to death. Scholarly work has been done from every conceivable angle, and this work is usually accessible to everyone. When it comes to books like *The Great Gatsby*, I have to wonder, what hasn’t been written yet?

Not only is there a wealth of scholarly criticism readily available but the way that we process information has drastically changed. With the advent of blogging, we have culturally shifted our style of writing. Personality and personal experience have permeated our discourse, and as readers we have become accustomed to reading this highly personalized and informal style of writing.

Our problem then is twofold: how do we shift the critical paradigm in a way that allows us to come up with fresh takes on canonical literature while at the same time adjusting for the new ways in which we process information?

Potential Solution to the Problem

The solution, I believe, lies in infusing our analysis with more personality, eschewing a more academic highbrow style, and opting instead to use our personal lives and experiences as the lens through which we interpret literature. The old style would have us cast aside our personal bias to examine a text from a formalistic standpoint. I advocate that instead of shunning our bias, we embrace it. Instead of working to view literature without a personal bias, we should work to interpret what literature means to us individually.

John Keats advocated what he called “negative capability,” or the idea that we must be able to place ourselves into the worldview of others to interpret the world as they see it. In the two hundred years since he wrote that, we may have tried too hard to follow that idea as academics, constantly forcing ourselves to view literature through a lens that is not our own, whether it be formalism, feminism, Marxism, or New Historicism.

By using our personal experiences and bias to inform our literary criticism, we make our work much more accessible to our readers who are accustomed to a more personal style of writing. Our personal bias and experience serve as

metaphorical “on-ramps,” allowing our readers to better identify with our analysis.

Example of the Proposed Solution

At the beginning of this chapter, I mentioned that the racial issues present in the *Great Gatsby* immediately jumped out at me during my recent rereading. I grew up in the rural South and attended a predominantly white high school. This isn't to say I only knew white people. Through church and work, I had plenty of African American friends, and because of this, I had this idea that racism was a bygone issue, despite the social problems that define the South to this day.

When I came to Brigham Young University, I experienced a different kind of society from what I had grown up with. Homogeneity rules BYU, not diversity; therefore, I had little to no experience dealing with racial issues as a college student. I left Provo after a year to serve a two year Latter-day Saint mission in Mexico City; keep in mind that I wasn't in the downtown touristy parts of the city. Instead, I was in the suburbs among what could best be described as the lower-middle class. For many people there, I was the first white person they had ever met and the first American they had ever seen. I arrived in Mexico right after President Bush had announced his intentions to build a wall along the Mexican border, so anti-American sentiments were running high.

For the next two years, I experienced something completely new: racism against me. People yelled profanities at me in the street, threw bottles at me, and called me offensive names. This didn't occur because I was a Latter-day Saint missionary in a predominantly Catholic country—none of my companions (who were all natives of Mexico) experienced this harassment—this happened to me simply because of the color of my skin.

For the first time I realized how horrific racism could be. The mental anguish I felt was excruciating. I wasn't being attacked for anything other than the color of my skin, and this got to me. For two years I struggled mightily as I was discriminated against and had no way of defending myself. I returned to America with a new awareness of racism, a new aversion to its evils.

It has been two years since I returned from Mexico, but that feeling of horror at being attacked because of my skin color has stuck with me. I've become much more socially aware since I returned, working hard to educate

myself about the world and the social issues that pervade it.

As I was reading *The Great Gatsby*, I couldn't help identifying with what I perceived as Nick Carraway's aversion to racism. Throughout the novel, Fitzgerald makes frequent allusions to the racial tensions of the time without ever directly addressing them. For example, in the first chapter, Tom Buchanan states that "if we don't look out the white race will be—will be utterly submerged," and "It's up to us who are the dominant race to watch out or these other races will have control of things" (Fitzgerald 17). Nick, as the narrator, doesn't directly address these issues himself; however, when Tom finishes the above speech, Nick says that "there was something pathetic in his concentration as if his complacency, more accurate than of old, was not enough to him anymore" (Fitzgerald 18). Fitzgerald doesn't directly say that Tom's racial prejudice is pathetic; instead he attacks his general demeanor. But this is an indirect attack on Tom's stance and views.

Throughout the novel, Tom is set up as the eventual villain. He is the arrogant rich boy, the philandering husband, the opposition to Daisy and Gatsby's love. Fitzgerald de-legitimizes racial prejudice by having it come from the mouth of the villain.

However, the fact that Nick never directly attacks Tom's viewpoint demonstrates an inherent internal conflict about racial issues. My own experience with racism led me to identify strongly with this response. Racism as a still-prevalent issue is something that has only come to my attention within the last few years of my life. There is undoubtedly an internal conflict occurring, a balance of what I experienced growing up versus what I experienced later in life.

While reading the text, I found this conflict to be a fascinating element; on the surface it would appear that Fitzgerald is directly attacking the racist views of Tom and his acquaintances. This was my original impression and idea, that Fitzgerald was covertly attacking racism. However, my ignorance of the circumstances of the time was leading me to oversimplify the issue. The more I read about racial issues in *The Great Gatsby*, the more I discovered that this conflict is central to its overall theme. According to much of the scholarly debate about racial issues in *The Great Gatsby*, Fitzgerald is denouncing racism via the viewpoint of Nick Carraway while simultaneously endorsing elements of commonly held racial philosophies.

A 1973 article by M. Gidley helped me to better contextualize the racial philosophies of the time, thereby allowing me to attempt to better understand

what Fitzgerald was trying to do with his novel. According to Gidley, Fitzgerald had read the works of Theodore Stoddard and Madison Grant, who wrote extensively about what they considered to be the decline of the great white race. Essentially they believed that the white race would be corrupted and eventually would fall due to its intermixing with other races, both reproductively and culturally. In his article Gidley demonstrates that at points in his life, Fitzgerald clearly sympathized with certain tenants of this philosophy. In fact, in a letter quoted in the article, Fitzgerald says that “it’s a shame England and America didn’t let Germany conquer Europe” because the dominant Germanic, Nordic race would have better run Europe as opposed to letting “the Negroid Streak” destroy it. (quoted in Gidley 178) It is important to note that Fitzgerald was referring to the First World War, not the later Nazi regime, but even still this letter contains shockingly racist sentiments that obviously refer to the philosophies of Stoddard and Grant.

This letter was written long before the composition of *The Great Gatsby*, and by the time of the novel’s writing, Fitzgerald’s viewpoints had obviously changed. The theory Gidley proposes in his article is that Fitzgerald used the character and narrator, Nick, to denounce the more overtly racist views while using the novel as a metaphor for the supposed decline of the white race. If we are to believe this theory, then *Gatsby* himself serves as a metaphor for the white race. Towards the end of the novel, Nick sees a limousine with several African Americans in the back being driven by a white chauffeur. This is right before *Gatsby*’s death and is an example of the way race serves as a metaphor in the book; here we see the white race in submission to the black race. *Gatsby*’s rise, decadence, and eventual fall are placed in contrast to this event.

Bringing my own thoughts and views on racism to the book led me to believe Fitzgerald was attacking racism in the novel. However, my lack of contextualization made me ignorant of the conflict Fitzgerald himself was feeling. He saw and felt a decline in society, a theme strongly stressed in *The Great Gatsby*. The popular philosophies of the time led him to denounce race as a cause of that decline. At the same time, he must have been conflicted about this issue, as Nick—the one arguably good character in the novel—is so repulsed by the racist ideas of other characters. *The Great Gatsby* and its composition then, from my perspective, are a metaphor for how we all deal with racial issues. We most certainly have ever-present biases and preconceived notions we are trying to overcome. Therefore, a conflict exists

within each of us, just as the internal conflict existed in F. Scott Fitzgerald when he wrote *The Great Gatsby*.

Conclusion

I could have analyzed this novel from a much more “academic” viewpoint by quoting a plethora of sources and making it available only on an obscure academic database. Instead, I chose to recount my own dealing with racism and hopefully explain how it influenced my reading of the book and then to publish this essay in a free eBook. My hope is that I have created a blend of the traditional academic techniques and the stylistic conventions of the digital age into something more readable, more relatable, and hopefully something fresh. If literary criticism is to survive in this digital age, it must adapt to become something new, different, and personal because everything else has probably already been written.

About the Author

Ben Wagner is currently pursuing a degree in English from Brigham Young University. He concurrently works as a producer for Classical 89 KBYU-FM. His interests include literature, classical music, sports, and all things British. He can be found online at his blog <<http://www.ben-wagner.com>> and on Twitter <http://www.twitter.com/ben_wagner>

Chapter 4

Stepping Over Joyce's Paralysis: Evolution of Secondary Sources

by Ashley Nelson

"The Sisters"

"There was no hope for me this time: it was my third stroke. Night after night I knew I was not long for this world. I kept waiting for the boy to come but he never did. I couldn't blame him. I wouldn't; I couldn't.

My mind was clear; almost as it had been before the incident. I believed it was God's way of saying he forgave me; I wanted it to be. What I had done warranted no forgiveness.

When Father O'Rourke left is when I felt the peace, the clarity. It was when I knew I was not long for this world. I hoped heaven would receive me."

Wait ... stop ... this is not James Joyce's story! The short story "The Sisters" from the collection *Dubliners* is told from the point of view of an unnamed boy. This boy had become friends with a priest, Father Flynn, who has just passed away. The boy has been expecting the priest's death but afterward, the boy doesn't know how to deal with the passing. This boy wishes "to go in and look at him but [he] had not the courage to knock" (Joyce 3).

But if this is the real story, where does this other version come from? It is not written by James Joyce but by me. It is what is called fan fiction. There is a website dedicated to stories such as these, fanfiction.net. On this site,

people can create their own stories based on another tale.

Researching in the digital age has changed rapidly over the last few years. The reason? There are so many resources and so much information that we can look at on the internet. Because of mediums like blogs, forums, and fan fiction, literary criticism is moving towards more informal sources. Secondary sources are changing from the formal to informal, from inactive to interactive, and from unsocial to social, and are just as legitimate as scholarly sources.

At the Start

During my research of James Joyce and his book *Dubliners*, I did not restrict myself to just the library. I had many methods of gathering information. I read blogs, went on forums, joined discussions, and read fan fiction.

These may not seem like official scholarly sources; teachers usually don't accept them in a formal research paper. Yet through these sources I was able to find the same amount of information, if not more, about James Joyce and *Dubliners* as if I had used official scholarly sources.

Maybe formal secondary sources have remained relatively the same, but informal secondary sources have sprung up everywhere today, changing the ways that we do research and interpret works of literature. People are writing blogs and joining forums to discuss the books that they have been reading. They are not scholars, but some of them make the same points that professional critics do.

We research and write to understand. When we read, we try to interpret and understand the words on the page. In order to understand, we research, whether informally or formally. After researching, we then try to create or write. By following this process, our thoughts mature and grow.

Informal Research

In my research I was able to contact several people about their readings of James Joyce. One blog I came across was written by a woman who actually lives in Ireland. It was interesting to see that her perspective on *Dubliners* changed as she spent more time in Ireland. She noted, just as James Joyce did, that people in Ireland do experience a sort of paralysis or at least a loyalty to their country and a reluctance to leave it.

Another blog, *Die Zeitschrift*, focuses on the character of Father Flynn and

notes that he has a “[desire] to confess something” (Joyce 2). As I was reading this blog, my eyes opened to Father Flynn’s little secret. At first I had been confused about the plot of “The Sisters.” I couldn’t make heads or tails of it: the conversations were confusing and facts were missing.

Once I read this blog, I went on a search to find more about Father Flynn and this sin that he believed he committed that caused him to be “sitting up by himself in the dark in his confession-box, wide-awake and laughing-like softly to himself” (Joyce 7).

One website, The Modern World, wrote an article about Father Flynn and his condition. His symptoms suggested his crime was sexual perversion. He was driven mad by his own guilt and by the disease he contracted.

These sources are legitimate even if they don’t have the stamp of scholarly attributes because they contribute in both analytical and social ways to the conversation about Dubliners. We as readers are part of a big, collaborative world, and most information is within easy reach

Formal Research

I was also able to find information I needed from approved scholarly sources. In one article, James Sullivan writes about James Joyce and the publishing difficulties that Joyce experienced with Dubliners (Sullivan). I decided to look into these publishing difficulties to find out more about Joyce’s life. James Joyce wrote about things he knew. His characters were often based on people he knew and he didn’t hide that fact. That was one of the reasons it was so hard to publish Dubliners and some of his other works. I have a suspicion that the unnamed boy in “The Sisters” might be based on Joyce himself.

Another reason that Joyce struggled in getting his work published was because of the content. His stories were often slightly inappropriate and made some people feel uncomfortable. James Joyce was creating based on something that had influenced his life, his time in Dublin. He was reproducing what he saw, which is what we all do in an attempt to understand.

Rob Tocalino has also remarked on James Joyce and his writing habits. Joyce did not look kindly on the people of Dublin. He wrote about Dublin and situations there in a more negative light than in his other works. Joyce believed that the people in Dublin were in a state of paralysis, unable to really progress until they moved away from Dublin. The characters in his stories

often wish to escape but few actually do (Tocalino).

I also turned to traditional research to learn more about the mystery of Father Flynn. After reading *The Atlas of Literature*, I reasoned that James Joyce went to Catholic school and learned a lot, so Father Flynn could be a representation of the Catholic Church. The little boy in “The Sisters” learned so much from Father Flynn that at Father Flynn’s death, he feels guilty of being free of him. I am not sure that James Joyce ever felt guilty about leaving the Catholic Church, but he did acknowledge its help in his education. Just as the little boy becomes distant from his emotions, James Joyce distanced himself from the church.

So, while I was able to find information about *Dubliners* and James Joyce on the internet, turning to traditional scholarly articles also helped me greatly in my research.

Fan Fiction

Just as I created the fan fiction about “The Sisters” to understand the story, we all participate in creation. I tried to put myself in the priest’s shoes, tried to imagine what it would feel like to be dying. After reading some blogs and forums, I was able to understand the character of Father Flynn. I tried to imagine how he would be feeling right before his death. Father Flynn would want redemption, but after feeling guilty for so long, he might think that forgiveness is beyond his reach. My version of the story may not be what James Joyce had intended, but it allowed me to connect to the characters in a way I had not before. It allowed for more interpretation.

In searching for more fan fiction stories, I came across Jude Mai’s “James Joyce’s *Araby* Pastiche,” which she wrote and posted to fictionpress.net.

“*Araby*” is about a boy who is infatuated with his friend’s sister. He has elevated her in his head and thinks being in love is great. He is so head-over-heels that he offers to go to a bazaar, *Araby*, to get a gift for her. To him, this market possesses a magical name, as if he is on a quest to some enchanted place for the one he loves. His illusion is shattered when he arrives and realizes as the story closes that he is “a creature driven and derided by vanity” (Joyce 19). The story drops off there, and we are left to wonder about the boy and what happened to him afterwards. Did he go back to his crush? Did he grow out of his boyhood fantasies?

The story that I came across answers some of those questions I had. In Jude Mai’s story, our young hero was just returning from *Araby*. As he was

leaving the train station he spots the girl that he was infatuated with in the arms of another man. Mai writes of the boy's heart being crushed. But then at the end of her story, the boy declares that it no longer matters because he is in love with someone else. I think it is an interesting take on the story of "Araby." The boy continues to go through these fleeting feelings for girls as if going to the bazaar had elicited no change in him.

These sites have enabled my reading of certain stories to alter and change. They give the audience a fresh perspective on characters they are familiar with and a chance to see how other people view and interpret the characters.

Nearing the End

Secondary sources, whether they are informal or formal, help us in our reading process. The secondary sources are evolving and moving away from the scholarly. The information shared on these sites does not take away from knowledge but helps it to grow because of the many minds that are now able to share and exchange information.

When writing a research paper about James Joyce, blogs and fan fiction may be helpful to refer to. These informal sources are as much interpretations of the text as an article and can be just as legitimate. Of course, informal sources cannot be the only sources we use, but a healthy mix of both informal and formal will help in creating a well-rounded paper.

About the Author

Ashley Nelson is a student at Brigham Young University studying English. She is an avid fan fiction writer and reader. See Ashley's blog at <<http://ashleynelson295.blogspot.com/>>.

Chapter 5

Creating Mockingbirds: The Importance of an Authorial Online Presence

by Alyssa Rutter

“For Harper Lee, [To Kill a Mockingbird] rolled out beautifully, it sold beautifully, it took on a life of its own, and its success had very little to do with the fact that she had to be out selling it. The book stood for itself. It would be nice to have that kind of a culture today, but we don’t anymore.» —Adriana Trigiani in Scout, Atticus, and Boo: A Celebration of Fifty Years of To Kill a Mockingbird

“Keep in touch!” Those three words had a prominent presence in my yearbook and bounced up and down the halls on my last day of high school. I was surprised when one of my best friends said instead, “You have got to get a blog. I’m never going to know what’s happening in your life if you don’t keep a blog updated.” My family was beginning to enter the blogging craze as well: mom, sister, aunts, cousins, second cousins, and cousins once removed (you think I’m kidding). So a couple of weeks after the graduation parties died down, I created myself online with a picture, a short bio, and an introductory blog post. Posting the link to Facebook legitimized it: from that day forward I was a blogger with a publicly available online presence, despite my amateurism.

Pressure to conform is increasing in intensity for those who are not making themselves known through the internet. Facebook, Twitter, personal blogs, and other sites are becoming requirements for keeping in touch and for both receiving and sending information quickly. The stakes multiply for modern authors with desires to be a part of both popular and high culture. Authors

who fail to enter with a strong presence into the digital age leave the door ajar for active members of the public to push in and create their presence for them.

Harper Lee

An aspiration to make an epic discovery for my class project started me on the search for contact information for Harper Lee, author of the classic American novel *To Kill a Mockingbird*. Some snooping produced this: Harper Lee has not granted an interview since 1964 (a mere four years after *Mockingbird*'s publication) nor published anything since *Mockingbird* in 1960 ("About the Author"). I was stunned and disappointed, then curious. Lee composed a Pulitzer Prize-winning novel on her first try, a beloved novel that spent eighty-eight consecutive weeks on bestseller lists, then abruptly dropped out of public view ("About the Author"). Why? My further search garnered intriguing results.

In her final public interview, Lee admitted that the attention was unexpected and overwhelming, almost "frightening" (Madden 162). Lee's sister Alice and friend Reverend Thomas Lane Butts explained that exploitation of her words and work, such as misrepresented interviews and autographed books, was disheartening (Murphy 71, 128). More intriguing, however, were accusations that *Mockingbird* was in fact the work of renowned author and Lee's longtime childhood friend and colleague Truman Capote.

Harper Lee closed herself off without giving the public a reason. Naturally, critics and readers alike ventured to understand the disappearance of the bestselling author. Lee, however, refused to give in. Most reader and critic explanations were positive and based on fact. One explanation, however, had its beginnings in fact but was skeptical: Was Truman Capote an unappreciated ghostwriter of *To Kill a Mockingbird*? Lee and Capote had been friends since kindergarten, written side-by-side in New York, and then helped to edit and do research for each other's novels ("About the Author"). And, of course, this was Lee's first novel, while Capote was already nationally acclaimed. Speculation circulated that after so much fame and publicity, Lee felt too guilty of hurting Capote's career to continue in the limelight.

Of course Alice, Lee's close friends, and the majority of *Mockingbird* scholars and readers pleaded and still plead for Lee's authorship of the book

(Block, Windham 5). But because neither Lee nor Capote has explicitly said otherwise, a few diehard Capote fans still believe that he penned *Mockingbird*. In 2003, Ben Windham crossed paths with Archulus Persons, Capote's father, who continued to claim that "almost all" of *Mockingbird* was written by Capote (5). Though today greatly outnumbered, these loyal followers have portrayed Lee in a negative light, posting opinions of both her and *Mockingbird* on blogs and forums across the internet.

To Kill a Mockingbird's popularity may not have suffered from the rumor that Truman Capote authored the piece, but the reading culture of the 1960s South is hardly comparable to the blooming digital age in which we now live. I echo bestselling author Adriana Trigiani in the belief that publishing and reading culture has changed since *To Kill a Mockingbird*'s publication; no longer can authors release a book and go into hiding as Harper Lee did (Murphy 184). Readers are beginning to turn to the internet to find more about a book or author; they generally either Google or guess the most obvious domain name, usually the author's name or the book title (Krozser 16, 18). Type harperlee.com into the address bar and a fan-based website with this disclaimer appears: "Please note that harperlee.com is a private website, unaffiliated with Harper Lee or her representatives." Instead of what Lee herself wants readers to know, an unknown entity includes what he or she considers to be worthwhile. Innocent readers can be deceived if they fail to read the small print.

Boo Radley

Mysteriousness, absence, and incomplete stories generate rumors; and few have told this tale more clearly than Lee herself. Through the narration of Scout, a young tomboy, *To Kill a Mockingbird* depicts the small town of Maycomb and the adventures of Scout, her brother, Jem, and their friend Dill while commenting on racism and assumptions in Southern communities. Arthur Radley, known to Jem, Scout, and Dill as Boo, is often talked about but has not been sighted since Scout can remember. Much of the children's entertainment comes from "the idea of making Boo Radley come out" (Lee 9), but they are too afraid to actually go up to the door to say hello, instead sticking a friendly note on the end of a fishing pole and unsuccessfully trying to dislodge it on a side windowsill (Lee 53). Readers and critics alike have been holding out the figurative fishing pole to Harper Lee and distant authors like her for years, but attempts have fallen short and we are once again left

subject to any information but the author's.

Very little time or creativity is needed to twist a story or description into a slightly less factual one, and this takes even less time to proliferate through a well-connected community. Never having heard anything different, Scout believes Jem characterizes Boo "reasonably": "[He] was about six-and-a-half feet tall, judging from his tracks; he dined on raw squirrels and any cats he could catch, that's why his hands were blood-stained... . There was a long jagged scar that ran across his face; what teeth he had were yellow and rotten; his eyes popped, and he drooled most of the time" (Lee 14). The children know only enough of the stories and descriptions, which Miss Maudie believes to be "three-fourths colored folks and one-fourth Stephanie Crawford," the town gossip, to create their own version of Boo based on corrupted facts (Lee 51). Jem, Scout, and Dill take for truth what they have heard, regardless of the source. They do not know what Boo Radley actually did or looked like, but because of "facts" circulating around their little town by those who are actively engaged in continual conversation with their neighbors, the children do not know where to get the real facts and likely do not recognize that their perceptions are skewed.

The same can be said for literature readers on the internet today. Just as Boo Radley's history, appearance, and even personality are formulated in the minds of many by rapidly spreading gossip in a tight-knit town like Maycomb and Harper Lee was accused of taking undue credit for *To Kill a Mockingbird*, authors leave their readers to pseudo online presences on the internet, where information spreads even more rapidly than in Maycomb. The internet is an impressive medium that is evolving daily, and as a result, authors must also evolve. Unless they use the resources available to explicitly form a legitimate online presence, authors lose control over how they are re-created and then perceived by the online literature community.

About the Author

Alyssa Rutter is a Brigham Young University sophomore studying English and editing. She is a musician, a learner, a reader, and a family enthusiast. Check out her blog at <<http://alymarierutter.blogspot.com>>.

Chapter 6

Toni Morrison and the Author - Reader Relationship in the Digital Age

by Andrea Ostler

How involved does a writer get in his or her readers' lives? How involved do the readers get in the writer's life? If we had thought about this question one hundred years ago, or even fifty, we would probably have said that there is very little involvement between the two. Literary theorist Roland Barthes certainly thinks so. In fact, Barthes's theories about an author who is essentially "dead"—meaning that the novel and its creator have nothing to do with each other—may seem logical in a nontechnological world. But in today's modern society and digital culture, we are seeing a drastic change in the author-reader relationship. Modern writers are connecting with readers through modern means of communication, essentially creating a living, working, and involved relationship.

Roland Barthes expressed that “‘to give a text an Author’ and assign a single, corresponding interpretation to it ‘is to impose a limit on that text’” (“Death of the Author”). I can see his point, but modern writers, an example being Toni Morrison, are showing that this is not the case. On the contrary, they are showing that the author should be there for their readers in order to expound on themes and issues that may be hard to understand and ultimately help the reader personally connect to the work of literature.

The Interactive Author

Toni Morrison was already a Nobel and Pulitzer Prize winner when her novel *Song of Solomon* was selected for Oprah's Book Club, the national book club of daytime talk show host Oprah Winfrey. Morrison had already established her artistic value as a postmodern author when she became a part of this dramatic example of postmodernism's union of canonicity and

commercialism. With Morrison's involvement in Oprah's Book Club, we see not only an integration of Morrison's academic audience and her popular audience but also an integration of her black audience and her white audience. Just as she defies literary norms in the plot and character development of her novels, she also defies the tradition of how authors must behave—particularly African American women writers.

What we see in Morrison is a new kind of relationship between the author and reader. Morrison was criticized for becoming involved in a daytime book club to promote her novels because up until then, writers usually took on the role of the secluded author, or, as Barthes coined, the “dead” author, and left the text to speak for itself. Morrison sought to make a different move. She continues to make a particular effort to connect with both high and popular cultures. She has remarked that “I would like my work to do two things: be as demanding and sophisticated as I want it to be, and at the same time be accessible in a sort of emotional way to lots of people, like jazz” (Young 187). She did this with her novel *Song of Solomon* both on and off her television appearances on Oprah.

The Reader's Response

I think of a powerful scene in *Song of Solomon* in which the protagonist's Milkman's aunt, Pilate, a powerful and wonderful character, is about to die. Typical to a Morrison novel, Milkman says goodbye to Pilate through a song: “‘Sing,’ she said. ‘Sing a little somethin for me.’ Milkman knew no songs ... but he couldn't ignore the urgency in her voice. Speaking the words without the least bit of a tune, he sang for the lady. ‘Sugargirl don't leave me here / Cotton balls to choke me / Sugargirl don't leave me here / Buckra's arms to yoke me’” (Morrison 336).

Morrison talks about her interaction as an author with a reader regarding this emotional scene in the novel: “A woman once got very angry with me because Pilate died. I told her that first, it was of no value to have Guitar kill someone nobody cared anything about. If that had been the case it would not show us how violent violence is. Some character that we care about had to be killed to demonstrate that” (McKay and Morrison 420). Morrison tries to show us this in the scene following Pilate's death: “Now he [Milkman] knew why he loved her so. Without ever leaving the ground, she could fly. ‘There must be another one like you,’ he whispered to her. ‘There's got to be at least one more woman like you’” (Morrison 336).

What helps readers connect with the issues surrounding sorrow and death is Morrison's application of these themes from real life. One reader who experienced this connection is Trudy Hamilton, a photographer and blogger. In a post about one of Morrison's appearances on Oprah's show and her comments about death, Hamilton remarks, "The fact that Toni is so emotionally evolved to fully acknowledge sadness truly moves me. Here's the thing ... nothing she said in [her] statement is 'negative.' The fact that she acknowledged what the pain feels like and realizes that this narrative is a part of her life story and in no way devalues her life or even her ability to do her work moved me to tears."

What both Morrison and Hamilton are doing is using digital media to reach a greater understanding and emotional connection to the literature and the author-reader relationship. Morrison is just one example of an author whose readers all over the world are actively participating in blogs, forums, and other social media to discuss important plots or themes of her literature. We also see a growing popularity for authors to create blogs themselves and involve their readers in the writing process. One such writer wrote about this author-reader relationship on her blog: "Thanks to technology, suddenly you can read your favorite author's blog and leave comments on it or send her messages on Twitter and get replies. It's amazing." But there is something else that this author considers:

"And yet it's still such a unique relationship. One of my author friends once told me how inadequate she feels at book signings because readers already feel like they know her through her books and it's almost like they want something intangible — some taste of what they found in the book and want to rediscover by meeting her. It's sort of crazy and sort of awkward and sort of understandable, all at the same time"(Mantyla).

The Digital Age Relationship

One website acknowledged that this changing relationship is itself a full-time job. Pat Ferrara wrote, "An author's website and blog have become full-time projects in and of themselves. While [a website or blog] may not be as entertaining as [the author's] next series installment, they put the time and effort to connect with you during the wait, take advantage of it" (Ferrara). While there are pros and cons to such an involved relationship between the author and the reader, I believe the pros win out. Just as Ferrara points out, the modes of connecting with the author that we have now in the digital age,

and ultimately the work that they create, are a unique opportunity for us as readers.

It's so exciting that authors are no longer "dead" to their readers. I think I can speak for many when I say that I love using the artist's background to help me connect to a work of art. Forums, blogs, and online discussions all help readers connect on a new level to a piece of writing. As a researcher and web browser, I love being able to access a blog like Trudy Hamilton's, where I can get another reader's perspective and insight about an author or a work of literature. Whether that of a Pulitzer Prize winner like Toni Morrison or a beginning writer, the life of the author and his or her active contributions to a work of literature is what perhaps should be most celebrated in this digital age.

About the Author

Andrea Ostler is a graduate in English and editing from Brigham Young University and is an avid blogger and blog follower. Check out her blog at <<http://andreaostler.blogspot.com>>

Chapter 7

The Age of Anonymity: Ender's Game and the Question of Online Identity

by Ariel Letts

"Perhaps it's impossible to wear an identity without becoming what you pretend to be." —Orson Scott Card, Ender's Game, 231

Today's digital age easily allows us to make connections with others who share the same interests. This instant communication has forced us to change the way we consume and connect with literature. Gone is the conventional research paper written for an audience of one. We are able to quickly spread our ideas about a piece of literature and receive meaningful feedback.

During my research of Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game*, I discovered an unfortunate lack of scholarly criticism pertaining to the novel. Undaunted, I consulted many of the new resources we learned about in my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class. Goodreads, Diigo, Twitter, and personal blogs became valuable resources to me in my search. Before the class, I was unaware of the great research potential those sites and others like them contained.

I found that as I searched through social sites like Diigo and Goodreads, I was more aware of the people who had posted the material. I took time to look at their names and pictures. If someone said something particularly interesting I would glance at his or her profile and get a glimpse of this person's life. It struck me how important our online identities are becoming in this rapidly changing digital age. With the emergence of the internet and its prominent place in our lives, it is almost mandatory to create an online identity for oneself. Students studying literature must sift through these identities and choose the best sources for research and learning. They must

glean information from the sources and form their own opinions without yielding to other viewpoints. With so much information readily available, students may find it difficult to maintain their individuality and core beliefs while being bombarded by alternate realities and philosophies online.

Our online identities and the way we communicate with each other set the stage for interactions on the internet, including how we influence and are influenced by other users. An online identity allows us to tell people a little about who we are or who we are trying to become. The authenticity of the online identity is entirely up to the author.

Is it acceptable to cultivate more than one identity online? Does that break the ethics of communication? I answer those questions with a resounding no. It is important to look at things from multiple perspectives in order to fully understand them. Multiple online identities add avenues of communication that may have been previously closed.

Online Identity in Ender's Game

Card's 1985 novel, *Ender's Game*, was groundbreaking. Amid the storyline of a six-year-old boy named Ender Wiggin, who leaves his family to train at the Battle School in preparation of the third and final war with the alien race called the Formics, or Buggers, Card creates a world where people interact with each other through the "nets," a forum-based digital environment where people met to discuss important political and social issues. Students are given handheld desks used for school research, as well as for sending other students private instant messages.

While Card got a few of the details wrong (he wrote his novel five years before the first web page was launched [<http://info.cern.ch>]), he successfully captured the essence of what is happening in our digital world today. From the importance of establishing an online identity to the multi-channeled way we tend to communicate, Card used his characters to highlight these areas of digital culture and illustrate their importance in the digital age.

Instead of focusing on the main character, Ender, I wanted to examine two of the minor characters in the story: Ender's older brother, Peter, and his sister, Valentine. Peter and Valentine have opposite personalities. From the first mention of Peter, the reader senses the rocky relationship between Peter and Ender. Card artfully uses Ender's thoughts to develop Peter's character, a much more effective device than reading an outsider's description. We immediately sense the fear Ender feels and the obvious resentment Peter

holds toward Ender. We understand this from the negative connotations and short flashbacks Ender experiences as he thinks about Peter: “I’m practicing piano, Ender. Come turn the pages for me. Oh, is the monitor boy too busy to help his brother? Is he too smart?” (Card 2).

Peter is motivated by his thirst for power and is ruthless and extremely intelligent. He will use whatever force or leverage necessary to achieve his goals. “[Valentine] couldn’t think of anything so terrible that she didn’t believe Peter might do it ... [but] he would only do it if the advantages outweighed the risks... . He always, always acted out of intelligent self-interest” (Card 125).

Valentine is Peter’s foil. She is full of compassion and would never deliberately harm another person, but she is also intelligent and understands how to manipulate people and their thoughts: “Writing was something Val did better than Peter... . [She] could persuade other people to her point of view—she could convince them that they wanted what she wanted them to want. Peter, on the other hand, could only make them fear what he wanted them to fear” (Card 127).

Peter, intent on ruling the world, manages to enlist Valentine to assist him in his plan. They create identities for themselves on the “nets” and use their pseudonyms as a way to share their ideas with others. “They used throwaway names with their early efforts, not the identities that Peter planned to make famous and influential... . They were deliberately inflammatory. ‘We can’t learn how our style of writing is working unless we get responses—and if we’re bland, no one will answer’” (Card 133). I think the fact that Peter and Valentine succeeded at influencing others at such a young age is fascinating. Everyone takes for granted that Peter and Valentine (as their alternate identities) are adults, and why shouldn’t they? Both Peter and Valentine have perfectly good solutions to worldwide problems. The internet is the perfect place for those who fear discrimination to voice their opinions. Computers “facilitate the dream of an egalitarian world which somehow comes to elude us in ‘real life’” (Kendall 130).

While Card uses Peter and Valentine’s alternate identities to comment on the digital society’s ability to manipulate the thoughts and actions of others, he uses Ender to illustrate the need for effective, honest communication. Ender unknowingly destroys the Bugger race, and we find out later that the Bugger invasion only occurred because of a lack of communication: “We are like you; the thought pressed into his mind. We did not mean to murder, and

when we understood, we never came again. We thought we were the only thinking beings in the universe... . How were we to know? We could live with you in peace” (Card 321). Effective communication is vital to our society today. Much heartache and confusion can come from simple misunderstandings, and the digital age only emphasizes the problem. By applying what Ender learned about communication to our modern predicaments, we can avoid similar misunderstandings today.

Connecting to the Digital Age

When I made the connection between what everyone in my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class was doing and what Peter and Valentine were doing (creating online identities), I could hardly contain my excitement. Had we really moved into a time that emulated something from a science fiction novel? I was amazed at the similarities and by the possibilities. Peter and Valentine were children when they gained notoriety: “‘Peter, you’re twelve.’ ‘Not on the nets I’m not. On the nets I can name myself anything I want, and so can you’” (Card 129). On the internet, it is easy to pretend to be anyone, or even multiple people. “People are able to build a self by cycling through many selves” (Kendall 132).

In the digital age, “students exist in both worlds simultaneously with the IOL [Institutes of Old Learning] promoting instruction and learning based on a relatively static, restricted set of print texts and using tired, extrinsic motivation approaches tied to narrow, academic, disembodied goals while NLS [New Literacy Studies] and new literacies document that children and youth are shifting from the page to the screen” (O’Brien 128). It is important to continue looking toward the future to avoid being trapped in “the increasing gap between literacy practices embraced by schools and policymakers and new literacy practices” (O’Brien 127).

In the digital age, understanding literature goes beyond merely reading and writing about it. We must study and experience it in its social and cultural contexts. When we do so, we engage with the text and draw more meaningful analysis and conclusions from it. When we share these insights with others who are also interested, we become part of an online community. We interact and share with others, our online identities begin to take shape, and we are welcomed into the digital group. Online identities have the power to elicit change in others; we must learn how to navigate through these identities while protecting our own ideas and morals. Only then can we truly influence

others in a positive way and contribute to the diversity of the internet.

About the Author

Ariel Letts is a junior studying English at Brigham Young University in Utah. She enjoys reading, movies, and everything science fiction. See Ariel's blog at : <<http://arielletts.blogspot.com/>>.

Chapter 8

Notes from an Editor: The Internet and Echo Chambers

by Nyssa Silvester

My Personal Underground

I spend at least 70 percent of my life editing. I study in one of the few undergraduate editing programs in the country; I work as a copyeditor and volunteer as a developmental editor; I edit for my husband in my spare time. Every night, I have to throw at least three books about editing onto the floor to make room for me on the bed. I constantly think about publishing, writing style, grammar, punctuation, and parallelism. And my internet use only compounds this single-minded lifestyle.

My Facebook friends are people I know from my editing and English classes. They are people who will offer me at least a smirk when I joke about how unreliable spell-check is or who can grasp a snatch of my joy in improving a manuscript. My Twitter feed is filled to the brim with authors, publishers, language commentators, and eBook aficionados. So even when I distract myself from my editing work, the subject still seeps into my consciousness from every direction.

On one occasion, I showed my husband a blog full of grammar and style errors, hoping I could get a laugh out of him. Instead, he gave me the wake-up call I so desperately needed: “Nyssa, not everyone cares about this like you do, and you’re being pretty elitist right now. Is the grammar really that important?”

I was shocked and a little upset when he first told me that, but I know he’s right. There must be millions of people who don’t care at all about the kind of work I do and at least thousands who hate it. I couldn’t see this other perspective, however, because of how editing saturated my life. And much of that saturation came from the friends, publishers, writers, and editors that I

had chosen to make up my digital experience.

Dostoevsky and Reflected Opinions

The extent of my internet insulation surprised me because I thought I was using these websites to connect with people who had different opinions and worldviews that I could learn from. But in these efforts to connect, I made two major mistakes: I surrounded myself mostly with like-minded people, and I didn't make a genuine effort to reach out to those who could offer a different perspective. In *Notes from Underground*, Fyodor Dostoevsky creates a nameless character who follows these same patterns of insulation to his social demise.

The entire first half of *Notes from Underground* comprises the Underground Man's rant against rationalism—the most curious aspect of this diatribe, however, is that the man consistently addresses an audience that doesn't seem to exist. The man speaks for both his argument and counterargument. "I swear to you, gentlemen," he first says, "that being overly conscious is a disease, a genuine, full-fledged disease" (5). Later in the same paragraph, he presents his counterargument through these imagined gentlemen of his own creation: "I'll bet that you think I'm writing all this to show off, to make fun of these men of action... . But, gentlemen, who could possibly be proud of his illnesses and want to show them off?" (5-6).

All of the Underground Man's opinions take the form of a mock debate with an imaginary audience. As Roger B. Anderson points out in his psychological analysis of *Notes from Underground*, such writing allows the Underground Man to compose "external events and people as revolving about himself." The Underground Man thinks he is generating legitimate counterarguments that he can defeat to prove his intelligence. But all the ideas in the first part of *Notes* come completely from one man's unhealthy mind: he does not really expose himself to opinions other than his own.

In the second half of *Notes*, however, the Underground Man begins to genuinely connect with another person—a prostitute named Liza, to be exact. He tells her how miserable her profession is, how she will be thrown away like trash as soon as her beauty fades, how whatever man she has in her life could not really care for her. After sharing this one evening of real emotional exchange, the Underground Man does not know what to do with such a connection. When Liza next comes to visit him, he yells at her, "Why did you come here? ... I'll tell you, my dear woman, why you came here. You came

here because I spoke some words of pity to you that time. Now you've softened, and want to hear more 'words of pity.' Well, you should know that I was laughing at you then. And I'm laughing at you now" (85). Here again, he forces words into an audience's mouth, in this case Liza's. He sets up his own opinion as his opposition. Perhaps afraid of genuine human interaction, the man's extreme reaction to Liza drives him to continue his life of solitude for years to come.

This same sort of intellectual isolation can come to us as we use the internet. The opinions we see as challenging our own may be no more than a variation of what we already think, while the rest of the world lies beyond our normal range of mouse clicks. Perhaps, like the Underground Man, we do not strive for a real human connection but just an affirmation of what we already believe to be true.

Breaking Out of the Echo Chamber

The echo chamber theory, widely circled on the internet, posits that, through the internet's emphasis on personalization, we see far fewer different opinions and resources than the vast stores of online information could offer us. Every time you rate a movie on Netflix, the site recommends a list of movies it thinks you would like, catering to your opinions instead of giving you objective access to all the films available. Facebook filters out the friends you click on least often, displaying only like-minded friends on your Newsfeed. Entire sites are dedicated to giving recommendations about media to consume, and this is a problem.

Prominent among other digital culture speculation is Chris Anderson's long tail theory. The long tail theory states that because the internet can reach niche audiences, those with different tastes from the mainstream, people will find and purchase more obscure media. These new audiences could buy titles that would have never received attention from the mass market. So, Anderson says, the internet allows for creators of these niche materials to find an audience and make money.

But echo chamber theory demands that we look at this consumption from the buyers' perspective. Though people on a large scale are purchasing all kinds of material, spanning across the entire range of taste and opinion, individual people see only that small amount of material that gets echoed back to them by their online personalization. Clearly no one person will consume every title possible, but the limits we unconsciously set for

ourselves through personalization are stifling considering the internet's possibilities. So what is our responsibility in choosing the media we consume?

We have to acknowledge that we really can't see everything, but we should at least be aware that we are missing plenty of valuable information. As NPR's Linda Holmes says, "There are really only two responses ... culling and surrender. Culling is the choosing you do for yourself. It's the sorting of what's worth your time and what's not worth your time... Surrender, on the other hand, is the realization that you do not have time for everything." But we can still branch out past the media that we know we'll like, that will only validate our opinions. We should strive to be well-read, well-educated, and well-informed; we can only reach those goals if we acknowledge the media outside of our personalized filters. Though we should not abandon what we love, we should consume enough different media that we can understand what others love. By making these efforts, we can form the genuine personal connections that the internet can provide.

Though I'm thoroughly entrenched in the editing underground, I can hear snatches of conversation from the world outside. The grammar and usage of these conversations might grind against my ears, but I can hear the passion people express for other subjects, for books I would have never thought to read. That passion is enough to draw me out into other perspectives, as difficult as that task may be. If I want to genuinely connect with other people, it is my responsibility to give heed to what they have to say.

About the Author

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Chapter 9

Digital Dichotomies: The Teachings of Henry David Thoreau with Respect to the Information Age

by James Matthews

Bruce Lee: A Case Study

Growing up, I idolized Bruce Lee. As a youth grappling with racial identity, Bruce Lee was one of few things that made the Asian part of being half-Chinese cool. What made him so different was his approach to martial arts. He rejected the fixed forms and set routines of traditional Chinese martial arts and introduced the Tao of Jeet Kune Do—a formless fighting system based on basic but revolutionary principles and movements. What is more, against the will of established Chinese martial artists, he defiantly shared this knowledge with Americans—in his own words, “teaching anybody who wants to learn” (quoted in “Kung Fu Culture”). His charisma, innovative technique, and fighting prowess brought him wide acclaim and success worldwide, bringing martial arts and Chinese culture into a more positive light within American pop culture.

At the peak of his popularity, Lee died suddenly, but his lasting legacy reveals the extent of his influence. His pupils diligently continued to teach his craft, but two opposing schools of thought quickly formed as to how Jeet Kune Do ought to be instructed. Many believed that Jeet Kune Do should be passed on precisely as Lee had taught it, maintaining a loyalty to Bruce Lee. Dan Inosanto, one of Lee’s first students and now his most influential, forwarded the notion that if people rigidly kept to Lee’s teachings, all the ideals that Lee embodied would be frustrated. The rejection of evolutionary thought would turn Lee’s freestyle methods into the same static practices that he had worked so hard to transcend.

Though artists of different disciplines, Bruce Lee and Henry David Thoreau are very similar in the way in which they divided their audiences.

Thoreau, in a Bruce Lee-like way, changed the landscape of American literature by rejecting accepted literary conventions and pioneering new methods, even a new genre—specifically placing himself within the laboratory of self-discovery by removing himself from the society that entrapped him. Thoreau recounted and detailed his experience in Walden in such a bold and deliberate manner that he provoked strong opinions in his readers, gathering followers and admirers as well as opposition in his wake.

Henry David Thoreau: Emerson's Poet?

To understand Thoreau in correct context, we need to understand his background. For as much as he desired to be a separatist the creator of his environment, to an extent he was a product of his environment. In 1844 Ralph Waldo Emerson, the great philosopher and instigator of American transcendentalism, published "The Poet," an essay issuing a call for the great American poet. In it he said,

I look in vain for the poet whom I describe... . which knew the value of our incomparable materials, and saw ... our [America] ... [though] yet unsung. Yet America is a poem in our eyes ... and it will not wait long for metres... . Doubt not, O poet, but persist. Say, 'It is in me, and shall out.' Stand there, baulked and dumb, stuttering and stammering, hissed and hooted, stand and strive, until, at last, rage draw out of thee that dream-power. (21)

Emerson's ideal may have not been realized within the semantic description of a traditional poet but rather in the embodiment of his star pupil, Henry David Thoreau, in the autobiographical account of Thoreau's life in the woods at Walden Pond.

In two chapters of *Walden*, Thoreau presents the views that have come to him as a result of his wilderness experience. In "Economy," an introduction to the experiment in which he is about to embark, he extols a Spartan existence and warns of the frivolity of technology:

It would be some advantage to live a primitive and frontier life, ... if only to learn what are the gross necessities of life and what methods have been taken to obtain them... . For the improvement of ages have had but little influence on the essential laws of man's existence; as our skeletons, probably, are not to be distinguished from those of our ancestors. (12)

He then outlines the anxiety with which society views his proposed lifestyle. It is evident that he is conscious of the opposition he faces, but his

experiment to learn the “gross necessities” and “methods” of life and the “essential laws of man’s existence” is too important to let that opposition stop him. He then describes the experimental economy he will impose upon himself, an economy that he hopes will draw the very best qualities out of him.

In “Solitude,” Thoreau rejects the common knowledge of the ordinary people around him and teaches about the value of introspection, saying that “we are for the most part more lonely when we go abroad among men than when we stay in our chambers” (Thoreau 142). Thoreau defied the prevailing viewpoints of the time and carved out a life of his own, gaining a profound identity through personal experimentation.

Though Henry David Thoreau did not fit neatly into the classifications of Emerson’s poet, he provides a sufficient case for his candidacy through how he displays the American frontier and new American thought through his writing. Robert Frost said of *Walden*, “In one book ... he surpasses everything we have had in America.”

Walden’s rhetorical value and place within history is legitimate then, and Thoreau’s experiment efficacious. Just as Bruce Lee gained notoriety and respect because of the success of Jeet Kune Do, so did Thoreau with *Walden*.

Within the context of today’s digital culture, literary students of Thoreau are now faced with a moral dilemma, a dilemma that was faced by disciples of Bruce Lee. Do we hold fast to the hard, rigid, direct words of Thoreau and reject the “improvement of ages”? Admittedly, I initially sided with this approach. I chose to read *Walden* for my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class as an act of rebellion. Henry David Thoreau, it seemed, stood for so many things that my professor, Dr. Burton, did not. In class we were instructed on the influx of digital culture in the literary stratosphere, but Thoreau shunned technology and went to the woods to discover himself, “to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, ... and suck out all the marrow of life” (96). That is what I wanted to do. I wanted to find out who I really was, not endure technology workshops for six hours a week. Interestingly enough, when I talked to Dr. Burton about my literary choice, he was genuinely excited, and it was evident that *Walden* had resonated with him before. Could a self-proclaimed “digital evangelist” also be stirred by the words of this transcendentalist teacher? It occurred to me that Thoreau was in actuality a scientist of the human soul, seeking to understand the laws and

principles that underlie humanity. His intentions could not be pigeon-holed into only one viewpoint.

Thoreau did not disregard the contributions of many great men but imposed certain innovative principles into the soul of man. Instead of rejecting railroads and newspapers like Thoreau explicitly advised, we should instead be careful not to accept everything without prior consideration. Naysayers may scoff because this philosophy explicitly contradicts Thoreau. Conversely, Ken Kifer, rhetorical critic, provides insight into the type of lens through which we must view Thoreau's words:

Walden is a difficult book to read for ... its logic is based on a different understanding of life, quite contrary to what most people would call common sense. Ironically, this logic is based on what most people say they believe. Thoreau, recognizing this, fills Walden with sarcasm, paradoxes, and double entendres. He likes to tease, challenge, and even fool his readers. And ... quite often any words would be inadequate at expressing many of Thoreau's non-verbal insights into truth. Thoreau must use non-literal language to express these notions, and the reader must reach out to understand. ("Analysis and Notes on Walden—Henry Thoreau's Text with Adjacent Thoreauvian Commentary")

With the proper perspective, we can understand the "spirit" of Thoreau's writing and not just the "letter."

It is enlightening to see how the "spirit" and "letter" camps of Thoreau's followers have responded to the invasion of digital culture. The anonymity, easy accessibility, and sheer amount of blogs, forums, and other digital literary sources have affected pedagogy in the digital age in two ways: now virtually everyone (pun intended) has received a "voice" and a platform to speak from; as a result, strength comes from a collective identity—a fusion of perspectives, ideas, and experiences. This idea is in stark contrast with academia's near worship of the intellectual genius of the individual. Knowledge is to be gained and shared, not kept in one person's intellectual vault, never to be released. The ever-reaching tentacles of technology allow a budding Thoreau in Burma to voice his thoughts or an aspiring Whitman in New Mexico to have greater influence than ever previously possible.

In the digital age, we will have to find a new way to filter and prioritize knowledge. Now that anyone can easily publish his or her thoughts, digital content can easily drift toward mediocrity and information overload. As a result, we must redefine scholarship and academic integrity. There is no

scholastic police force that patrols cyberspace and punishes trolls, thoughtless or ignorant bloggers, and spammers. In spite of this lack of moderation, the internet brings a huge academic benefit: the process of sifting, prioritizing, and internalizing in solitude all the information available is invaluable to the learning experience. This solitary work is itself a schoolmaster that produces better readers, critical thinkers, and experienced analysts.

So who today answers the call as Emerson's modern-day Poet? Is it the two cofounders of Google who revolutionized our capacity to research and gather information? After all, Google made it possible for a Tibetan student in the Himalayas to see pictures of Walden Pond. Is Steve Jobs our Romantic leader of twenty-first century transcendentalism? The iPod allows a young girl in Ecuador to hear the notes of a beautiful Italian opera. I say that Emerson's poet is both of these people, all others like them, and even you. You and I will have to front the essential facts of life—that we live in a different age than Thoreau, that it is impossible for us to neglect digital culture. We will all have to deliberately learn to use technology, coming to know wealth of opportunities it affords us. The power of the digital age is the collective movement towards self-actualization. The odds that one blog will have the answers to life's most profound questions are slim, but more important than one great American poet is a great American people. So is it too radical to believe that technology can enhance literature in the digital age? Henry David Thoreau and Bruce Lee probably wouldn't think so.

About the Author

James Matthews is from Washington, DC, and is working on his BS in Organizational Behavior at Brigham Young University. He works as substitute teacher in the Latter-day Saint seminary program and passes the time by playing basketball and tennis and by cycling. He can be found online at : <<http://jamesmatthewseng295.blogspot.com/>>

Chapter

One Nation, Under Google, with Wikipedia and Access for All: “Information Entitlement”

by Derrick Clements

As Stephen Sondheim and John Weidman point out in *Assassins*, their musical about nine successful or would-be assassins of US presidents, a sense of entitlement comes naturally out of hearty, rights-respecting American tradition. In the play, that sense leads everyday losers to take violent action when they don't attain what they feel are their privileges as Americans. In the digital culture of the twenty-first century, a similar sense of entitlement causes us to expect information, access, and the speed of instant gratification.

Bored

I sat in a computer lab in the basement of Brigham Young University's library, receiving instruction from a full-time staff librarian who is in charge of all the research materials—both books and online databases—relating to the English department. He demonstrated how to navigate the various databases by searching for works relating to Jane Austen.

“Type her last name first in the search—that will get you better results,” he said, and then he proceeded to show us a dozen other effective techniques for database searching in the library's system. He talked about truncating our search terms, using correct Boolean language, and most importantly, he showed us which search engines to use depending on our needs.

He pointed out that instead of the big general search bar on the library's main page, he recommended switching to the old library view to manually determine which databases to search. If we went through a rather convoluted series of search steps, we could find exactly what we were looking for online.

Your reaction to that story separates you into two groups.

If you were thrilled that through the use of internet search technology, researchers are now able to find exactly what they are looking for without

leaving their own Cheeto-stocked basement, you belong to the group called the Old Old Old Old People. You're grateful, optimistic, and, most likely, you're well educated (a process that, for you, involved hours with note card databases in dusty, windowless rooms).

However, if you reacted the way I did, you were frustrated that the main library search bar right on the front page of the library's homepage was not sufficient for your nearly limitless needs, and you belong to the other group, the Post-Google Techno-Entitled Whippersnappers.

We are a generation that has grown up accustomed to readily available information on any subject. Even interpersonally, we send out text messages to our peers with the assumption that not hearing back from them means they don't like you (it couldn't mean that they are dead, because if they had been in a tragic accident, you would have been notified on at least seven different digital devices and social networks within five minutes). We want access to music, videos, information, and more, and we want it immediately. And we want it for free.

Access is the Mantra

But as Lawrence Lessig writes in his book *Remix*, we don't necessarily expect the access to be for free. He writes about an experience looking for online clips of the Academy Awards. He didn't want to watch them live but wanted to find one acceptance speech from someone he knows.

Access is the mantra of the YouTube generation. But not necessarily free access. Digital technologies will thus shift the expectations surrounding access. Those changes will change other markets as well. Think of the iPod—perfectly integrating all forms of read-only culture into a single device. That integration will increasingly lead us to see the device not as music player or video player but as a universal access point, facilitating simple access to whatever we want whenever we want (Lessig 46).

If something is available for purchase, the whippersnapper generation have proven that they will pay for it. But if that is not an option, they have no problem stealing. It doesn't feel like stealing, because they feel that they have a right to the access.

“Everybody Has a Right”

The disgruntled characters of Assassins may not care about access to entertainment or knowledge, but as Americans, they feel entitled to an

audience for their voice, as well as to protection of the basic rights under the law. And when they don't receive either of those, they feel justified in taking action against the symbol of those rights: the US president.

People who download music illegally don't consider themselves to be criminals. Likewise, the assassins of Assassins don't consider themselves murderers. They don't consider the killing they do to be murder.

In scene 16, John Wilkes Booth tries to convince Lee Harvey Oswald to shoot President Kennedy:

OSWALD: I didn't come here to shoot the President.

BOOTH: He didn't come here to get shot. All your life you've been a victim, Lee. A victim of indifference and neglect. Of your mother's scorn, your wife's contempt, of Soviet stupidity, American injustice. You've finally had enough, so how are you planning to get even? By becoming your own victim.

OSWALD: I'm not a murderer.

BOOTH: Who said you were?

OSWALD: You just said I should kill the President.

BOOTH: Lee, when you kill a President, it isn't murder. Murder is a tawdry little crime; it's born of greed, or lust, or liquor. Adulterers and shopkeepers get murdered. But when a President gets killed, when Julius Caesar got killed—he was assassinated. And the man who did it—(He lets the sentence hang, unfinished)

OSWALD: Brutus.

BOOTH: Ah! You know his name. Brutus assassinated Caesar, what?, two thousand years ago, and here's a high school drop-out with a dollar twenty-five an hour job in Dallas, Texas who knows who he was. And they say fame is fleeting.

As the author, John Weidman has written about the play after the fact: "Assassins suggests ... we live in a country whose most cherished national myths, at least as currently propagated, encourage us to believe that in America our dreams not only can come true, but should come true, and that if they don't someone or something is to blame" (quoted in the preface of the 1991 edition of the book).

John Wilkes Booth is set up as being feared and respected by the other assassins in the opening number of the show (the characters cross boundaries of time and location in order to interact and talk to each other). In scene 2, in which he kills Abraham Lincoln, he passionately feels the need to write down

his reasons for shooting the president so that he would not go down in history only as a murderous madman. In his mind, he felt justified as a Southerner with certain rights that were taken away because of the Civil War.

Sam Byck, who attempted to assassinate Richard Nixon, performs a long monologue in scene 9 in which he exposes a very American right that he feels entitled to: the right to be heard. He records his monologue onto a tape to send to Leonard Bernstein (who, incidentally, was the composer for one of Sondheim's first Broadway musicals, *West Side Story*). Byck feels a sort of angry fandom toward Bernstein because through his music he has a voice that Byck doesn't have: "You'll indulge me for a minute if I say something from the heart. You're a genius. Yes, you are! And you know why? You understand what people want. You have their ear. You make 'em listen, Lenny. No one listens. Are you listening?! No one listens" (55). (Maybe if Sam Byck had been able to make a blog, he would have been satisfied with his voice.)

The catchy tune of "Everybody's Got the Right" makes the point that in America, we grow up expecting to be able to have rights and aspirations. "No one can be put in jail for their dreams," they sing.

The Assassination of the Old Way

Bloggers may not be violent, but it is worth a pause to consider what they are attempting to assassinate. The library system, the classically trained professor—they are victims of Wikipedians and Wikileakers, who feel that any shlub with a keyboard (like the dropout Lee Harvey Oswald) should have a voice.

One criticism that the authors of *Assassins* received upon opening (the play, despite being Sondheim's personal masterpiece, did not last long and was received poorly), was that they seemed to justify the heinous crimes of these assassins of our history. And it does feel strange to attempt to see the world through the eyes of a killer, but likewise, the bloggers and downloaders of today—who feel totally justified in assassinating the old way of finding information and content—have a point. Libraries would be better off updating their systems to match the Google algorithm. But when our sense of entitlement pushes us to break the law or cut ethical corners or kill a US president—then it has gone too far.

About the Author

Derrick Clements has been writing about entertainment since 2002. You can find more of Derrick's work by visiting <http://derrickclements.net/>.

A Letter From Hell: Screwtape on the Digital Age

By Taylor Gilbert

“Remember not all entertainment in this digital age has the gloriously sickening effect that we desire ... Good literature is often irreversibly destructive regardless of the format in which your patient may digest it.”

My Dear Wormwood,

It seems as though you are doing a marginal job with the patient lately. I was much pleased to hear of his newly acquired “Facebook” habit. Much good has been accomplished by our Father Below in this newly developing area. Not only do the little animals not realize that they are wasting what short time they have, but they actually believe that they enjoy it! Be very careful though, my dear Wormwood. You must remember that every temptation is a gloriously perverted tool originally created by the Enemy to bring the humans foul happiness. Hours of self-centered entertainment can easily be converted into a wretched social discovery if not monitored carefully.

Never before have these animals been able to communicate with such ease. The cooperation and cohesiveness that is attainable in this the digital age is enough to make even the most senior tempters uneasy. Your patient must never realize that his hours of useless meandering, if slightly altered, could bring him untold satisfaction.

Complacency is the greatest tool in our Father’s arsenal. The same principle applies here, my young nephew. Think back to my advice concerning prayer. “The best thing to do when the patient is an adult, recently reconverted to the Enemy’s party, is to remind him of his parrot-like prayers from his childhood. Otherwise, he may be persuaded to aim at

something spontaneous, inward, informal, and un-regularized” (Lewis 15). These prayers result in answers from the Enemy and wretched happiness and satisfaction for the patient.

The same principle can be utilized in your current situation. Never let the human see the opportunities that lie before him. Remind him that he is comfortable with the amount of interaction he has with his cyber peers. Foster in him an attitude of fear (another formidable arrow in our quiver) toward publicizing his information. Work to convince him that cooperation is dangerous and inferior to other forms of research and production.

Hornswallow and Greenfleck have spent considerable effort convincing a very aristocratic group of academics that social media is a somehow lesser form of communication and research. Brilliant, isn’t it? Their most influential voices in literary circles believe that this treasure trove of information is worthless because it is informal. Remember, Nephew, to instill a feeling that difficulty to access information equates value, as opposed to the veracity of the content.

We have won many battles in this war on free thought. Firstly, one of our greatest victories is that there are volumes upon volumes of disgustingly brilliant ideas created by these little monsters hidden safely behind restricted access databases, unsearchable to all but a few, with even fewer who know how to find the information they seek. Secondly, we have convinced humans that the idea behemoth called the blogosphere is “unreliable” and “a passing trend.” The fools! Even one of their authors—a Mr. Nicholas Carr—has written that the internet is making humans stupid. He is correct to a point. But only because we, through temptation, and this ruling academic class have taught them to use their tools to their own destruction.

I’m also quite worried about the types of entertainment that you have been allowing the patient to indulge in lately. Remember, not all entertainment in this digital age has the gloriously sickening effect that we desire. I am much unnerved by your failure to persuade him against consuming audiobooks. Good literature is often irreversibly destructive regardless of what format your patient may digest it with.

Let us recall one of your earlier mishaps when you “allowed him to read something that he really enjoyed, because he enjoyed it and not in order to make clever remarks about it to his new friends” (Lewis 64). In short, you allowed your patient to feel something real. Your motto must be façade, smoke, and misdirection. When one of the dirty humans sees reality, it brings

a putrid sense of enlightenment and clarity. I hope that you are beginning to perceive your fault in relation to audio, Nephew.

When your patient listens to a work of literature, it is much more difficult to distract him from his feelings of reality. At least when a patient is reading a physical book, we can contain the problem to that world and those characters in the author's fabricated world, thereby not letting those ideas seep into the patient's actual life. Yet, as he listens, his world becomes the foul story in which he is engrossed, and before long the patient begins to draw parallels to his own life, and before you even have the chance to think of a distracting temptation, the patient has already planned changes in his life. My dear nephew, do not be distracted by the amounts of time he must invest. This is one investment that has a disgustingly large return.

I must close for now, Wormwood. Remember, if these little monsters ever realize the true worth of these aids given to them by the Enemy, our job will be much more difficult. If we are to be successful in these our endeavors, we must be conscious of two of our greatest tools in this digital age, complacency and unreality. I await your next letter with much anticipation in hopes that you will correct the error of your ways.

Un-affectionately,
Screwtape

About the Author

Taylor Gilbert is a sophomore at Brigham Young University studying English. He loves reading, sports, and most of all spending time with his family. Check out his blog at <<http://taylorrygilbert.blogspot.com/>>

Chapter

Serious Simulation

by Matt Harrison

*We may think what we are doing is a simulation or is preliminary,
but we have already become a part of something real.*

The Battleroom

“The enemy’s gate is down” (Card 172) is the famous line given by Ender to his army when they are about to embark into the battleroom. Ender said this line to expand his army’s thinking. In the battleroom there is no gravity and no friction: the only rule is to win. The battle pits each army of kids against another in a laser-tag battle. The last person not tagged wins the battle for his army. The battles are just a game to these seven- to sixteen-year-old kids. But the truth is that this “game” is real and has real implications. The game is a simulation to help these kids train for a real war by commanding, deploying troops, and coming up with strategies to defeat the enemy. Much of the digital culture that my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class has studied relates perfectly with this analogy. We may think that what we are doing is a simulation or is preliminary, but we have already become a part of something real.

At the end of the book version of Ender’s Game, the adults use Ender and his jeesh (team) to win a war that Ender has no idea has already begun. Ender has been tasked to destroy an entire race of aliens who threaten to invade Earth. Ender thinks he is playing a simulation—a game with fake ships and an opponent who he thinks is his teacher. But in fact, he is winning the war he thought he was preparing for. He commands fleets of real lives and wipes out an entire race of aliens, but the only way the adults can ensure that Ender will not get overwhelmed at this responsibility is to lie to him and tell him the battle is a simulation. This scenario is how the digital culture operates as

well, especially when it comes to the modern use of comics.

Comics (The Beta of Movies)

Comic books are not just comics anymore: they are the beta of movies. (A beta is the preliminary or testing phase that many internet sites or software companies go through before launching the real product. It gives room for changes and tweaks according to the users' preference and feedback.) Comics have become a treasure map to finding gold. Comics are not profitable, at least not the \$2.99 versions. So why continue to make comics? Because comics are a means to an end. Like Ender's battleroom, comics are a simulation for the real war. Marvel, for instance, releases comics in order to see which character and story arc have become popular. The company uses this information to create movies that gross millions of dollars.

Marvel started to use comics as a gauge for movie possibilities around 2005. It had already come out with its big hitters—Spider-Man, Fantastic Four, The Incredible Hulk, and X-Men. Marvel did well, but the company also had some busts and didn't know which character should be put on the silver screen next. Meanwhile, Orson Scott Card wrote a comic called Ultimate Iron Man, which quickly became a bestseller. Up to this point, Iron Man had been a background character with a small following. Marvel made the movie Iron Man in 2008 and turned a \$2.99 comic into three hundred million dollars (total gross income of Ironman). So every time I embarrassedly sneak a comic into the house past my wife and read it alone in a dark room where no one can find me, I am really contributing to society! And who says comics are useless?

The Betas We Use Every Day

In the same vein as comics' being a beta for movies, digital culture is full of betas that we need to take seriously. Everything we do in the digital culture has an impact. We may think we are in the kiddie pool, but in fact, we are swimming in the middle of the ocean. The first MP3 player wasn't hugely popular and didn't really catch on, but it was the first of an evolving system that led to the iPod. Once the iPod took over, it evolved into a smartphone. Digital culture is constantly evolving because of us, and it is up to us to determine where it goes.

I didn't realize how many mainstream websites are actually still in beta form. According to the Museum of Modern Betas (MoMB), some of the top

100 betas include such websites as hulu.com, flickr.com, prezi.com, wolframalpha.com, gmail.com, and so many more. This means that the Gmail that I use every day is still in its testing phase and will continue to grow and change according to how I (and millions of other users) use it.

Our Second Life

World of Warcraft (which I do not play, and if you do, that is A-OK. I am not one to judge ... I read comics) started as a beta. The beta was basically the first game. Once the people at Blizzard saw the flood of people wanting to play, the company made significant changes to the game. Now World of Warcraft is the world's top-selling computer game and currently has twelve million users.

Another MMORPG (Massively multiplayer online role-playing game. You should probably learn what this is, since it is taking over everyone) like World of Warcraft, is Second Life. Second Life is exactly what it sounds like: it is a simulation of your life (but you can fly if you choose). This "simulation" is not a simulation to the players—it is real. The game has real currency and a real government with real elections. People will sell things in Second Life on eBay for real money. Crazy, I know. But this is exactly my point: these simulations that are all around us are real if we take them seriously.

My Experience with Bean

In Ender's Game, one person who knows that the battle simulations are real is Bean. Bean understands that the kids are commanding real lives, so when Ender is about to sacrifice an entire fleet to beat "the game," Bean is the only one to thank the men about to give the ultimate sacrifice. We need to be like Bean. We need to be aware that we are a part of something bigger.

Before I blogged, I thought like Ender. I thought that as a college student, things I did were inconsequential and that I would make an impact on the world in my forties and fifties. I thought that my blog would only be read by my teacher and that no one would appreciate an entire blog dedicated to comics. But now I realize that it was all a façade. My blog was being read and appreciated, and secretly, I had just been given a voice on the internet.

The more I gained a voice, the more I realized how serious comics need to be taken. This realization came to fruition when I went into the basement of Brigham Young University's library to the Special Collections section. Special Collections is dedicated to holding only rare and valuable works. To

get a book from there, you practically have to pass a background check. Well, imagine my surprise when the comic book I was looking for was in this holy-of-holies section of the library! It hit me when I was sitting in the designated reading room and I looked around me sheepishly, waiting for my comic book while everyone else there had gloves on and was studying ancient manuscripts—I knew then that comics had become a thing to be reckoned with. Then I considered donning white gloves to give respect to the comic I was about to read. (I didn't, and I think I might have even ripped a page on accident. Don't tell the library, please.)

I have forsaken my “Ender ways,” and now I think like Bean. We should all awake and realize that this class, this eBook, and everything we do are not assignments or practice but real and important. We are all part of a test, and we need to realize that we are taking it in order to pass. I now know that the “enemy's gate is down” , and I am ready for the real battle. (Card 172)

About the Author

Matt Harrison is a student at Brigham Young University majoring in English and minoring in Buisness, he hopes to continue his studies at BYU to earn his MBA. He enjoys movies and literature (which includes comic books and not responding to emails. Matt is marreid and originally from Potomac, MD. Check out his blog at <<http://matthewharrison1987.blogspot.com/>>

Alternate Worlds: Borges and Digital Reality

by Rachael Schiel

“The other one, the one called Borges, is the one things happen to... . Little by little, I am giving everything over to him,” wrote Jorge Luis Borges of his relationship with himself (“Borges and I”). Borges, more than any other author I have ever read, is acutely aware of the many realities we create for ourselves. The first time I read “Borges and I,” I stared at the page for long minutes in astonishment: Borges had articulated a truth which I had struggled to recognize in words for many years. Humans are composite creatures, and reality is a composite entity. In a world of virtualization and digitization, Borges’s truth is a powerful one to consider: Reality is what we give credence to, not what others (or tradition) assume to be real. It is a truth that is supported by the evidence of the digital age.

“Death and the Compass”

The internet and associated media allow us to choose the realities we prefer, much like how Borges’s character Erik Lonrot chooses to see the world as a place of mysticism in the short story “Death and the Compass.” A detective on a serial murderer case, Lonrot is excited by mysterious notes left by the murderer at the scene of every crime. Lonrot becomes obsessed with Hebrew mysticism, convinced that he can use it to “divine the secret morphology of the vicious series” (Borges 1). Unbeknownst to him, the murderer has chosen to play the part of a mystic precisely because he knows it will lure Lonrot into a trap. Lonrot chooses to believe in certain truths, and then those truths become his reality.

I, like Lonrot, have experienced the lure of creating my own reality in the form of online avatars and profiles and games. I was a part of the middle school Neopets© frenzy of feverish “Neopoint” collecting and pet care; I

have dabbled in online gaming and, with near shame, experienced the thrill of “level-upping.” These things seem less innocuous, however, when compared with the ways in which absorbing myself in my online identity has, at times, jeopardized my “other” reality—that of home, family and friends.

I will never forget the rainy high school night when my father and I almost broke into physical violence over my Facebook password, which I refused to give him. I remember staring in disbelief at the computer screen afterwards. “What was I thinking?” I asked myself. I wonder if Qiu Chengwei asked himself the same thing after stabbing his friend over an online gaming dispute in 2005 (“Chinese Gamer”). Despite what we tell ourselves about the lines we keep between reality and “virtuality,” as Borges says, we come to understand “with relief, with humiliation, with terror ...that [we] also [are] an illusion” (“Circular Ruins”). Only our conviction of reality authenticates that reality.

Integrating Art

Noam Cohen of the New York Times has stated that Borges “uniquely, bizarrely, prefigured the World Wide Web” with his conception of infinite stores of information and the ways in which those stores would alter the human experience. A form of information—one that greatly enhances our conviction that the digital world can be a form of reality—is the graphic information that is ubiquitous online in the form of artwork, photographs, and the like.

As I was researching Borges’s present-day effects on the internet community, I stumbled onto a personal blog that discussed his “Library of Babel” and its relevancy to the topic of RDF and RSS integration (Mazzochi). What struck me as most impressive about this blog was the picture posted with it—a gorgeous painting of a crumbling, circular tower. A blog is inherently a personal form of communication, but it was really the picture—with fanciful blues and solemn browns—that pulled me headfirst and intimately into the pith of what the author was trying to say: even limitless stores of information are a relic without an effective way of organizing them (like, say, a search engine on an internet browser). The blogger’s argument was more convincing to me—and I accepted it as valid, real—in part because of the use of art.

Art has a way of striking the emotions more instantaneously than words can. Language must be decoded a symbol, a word at a time; art has an

immediate impact. Perhaps that is why advertising is primarily a visual science—it goes for the visceral reaction. If this is true, then the internet may be a more impactful medium for experiencing literature than the more traditional codex—it has the potential to market the literature because of its higher capacity for visual enhancement.

“The Library of Babel” and “Tlon, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius”

Imagine juxtaposing a short story of Borges’s with visual artwork by Escher, much like how the blogger I found juxtaposed his words with a work of art. It has been argued that Escher’s print “Ascending and Descending” is thematically comparable to Borges’s “The Library of Babel,” which discusses the implications of an infinite library of information that winds around and around on itself (Parker 18). Putting the two works together could make experiencing both of them more emotional and more comprehensive. The reader becomes aware of the arguments presented by both works and is convinced of the potential “reality” of each. Art convinces us to lend credence to reality; the internet is possibly the most effective medium for displaying art and text together. The internet displays another reality to us, and we accept it.

Or, for another example, go back to the online gaming world, where three-dimensional “graphical worlds are comprehensively mapped, giving a sense of spatial other-place through the screen ... [which] gives users a sense of being in a world” (Calleja 98). In Borges’s short story “Tlon, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius,” enough people accept the reality of a make-believe world called Tlon that the idea of that world starts interfering with reality, changing it to be more like this imaginary other-world. The advanced visuals of cyberspace seem to have the same effect on gamers who believe fervently in the reality of their online games. William Gibson, a cyberpunk author, has called such activity a “consensual hallucination” (Calleja 95). As Borges said it, “The world will be Tlon” (“Tlon, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius”).

The internet has proved to be more than just another way to transfer information; it has become its own entity with its own power and personality. The digitization of everything from literature to job interviews to gaming is proof of the internet’s power to change our outlook on what the world can be. As more of our culture decides to “give everything over” to the realities presented by the online world, we will see more of Borges’s inadvertent prophecy coming true: reality will be only and exactly what we choose it to

be.

About the Author

Rachael Schiel is a sophomore at Brigham Young University who believes that summer dresses and chocolate chips are evidence of a benevolent God. You can read her blog online at : <<http://rachaelschiel.blogspot.com/>>

Chapter

“Some Text”: E. B. White’s Web of Primary Texts

by Carlie Wallentine

Some people you meet, artists, intellectuals, business people, technological innovators are having a great time because we are inventing so many new things, we are in a whirl, or an extraordinary whirlwind, in which there are all kinds of stimulation. The people who are excluded from this system are not simply poor, exploited or even irrelevant, they’re those who don’t understand this enjoyment of creativity and innovation. That’s why we’re living in two different cultures: a culture of bewilderment about the world we live in and a culture of innovation, creativity and the opening of new frontiers (Castells 4).

To everyone who did not have the privilege of being raised on a farm, I am sorry. Your childhood was severely robbed! I was raised on a farm located in the southeast corner of Idaho, and it was there that I learned every life lesson needed to survive. I worked hard all year round; I learned how to improvise, sacrifice, gain, lose, and love. I learned about death and, more importantly, I learned about life. One night in particular taught me what it means to live and connected me with Charlotte’s Web, which is why I chose to spend an intense seven weeks studying E. B. White’s story of Wilbur the pig’s quest to live a long life.

For weeks our family had been awaiting the arrival of a litter of piglets. One night I happened to glance out the window and see that the pigs’ light was on, and I instinctively knew why. My dad had gone over earlier to check on the pig. So I grabbed my coat and slipped my rubber boots over the top of my pajamas and ran across the road. I took the shortcut through the hole in the wall that dumped me right into the pigpen, and I saw my dad sitting to the side watching a handful of baby piglets squeak and squirm around for their

first meal. My dad pointed to a small little porker and said, “There’s Wilbur.” As I look back on this memory after examining Charlotte’s Web, I recognize the compliment that little piggy was unknowingly given. Wilbur’s story is a classic about love, life, and friendship, and of course a little gluttony brought to us by Templeton the gluttonous rat.

The Primary Text

The entirety of this Writing about Literature in the Digital Age course has been devoted to exploring, creating, consuming, and evaluating literature in nontraditional ways. This course of action questions what is considered to be the primary text of a piece of literature. With new technology being developed on a daily basis, it is understandable that the arts should not go unaffected. The traditional primary text is the physical book that is published and sold in bookstores; however, using nontraditional adaptations of a novel, such as film, audio, or other versions, will create a new experience and understanding of the text, an experience unique to each form and beneficial to readers.

The Traditional Book

I started my research project on Charlotte’s Web by reading the original text E. B. White wrote back in 1952. I love this book; it brings back fond and not-so-fond memories of my childhood. I literally laughed out loud when I read the beginning lines about Fern being “up at daylight, trying to rid the world of injustice” (5). I’ve heard this line quoted to me countless times from my own father.

There is something special about reading a book. Ironically, a man named Wilbur D. Nesbit authored a poem about books which begins, “Who hath a book / Has friends at hand, / And gold and gear / at his command” (Felleman 629). Mr. Nesbit was very wise: the printed text is like a friend. There is an indescribable relationship that the reader forms with the pages, cover, and feel of the printed book. Tammy Stephens, an English teacher, incorporates other mediums of the text in her lessons but emailed me her feelings on reading the printed text. She said, “I truly believe one cannot fully experience an author’s words without reading those words. Probably, the book on an electronic device is very good, but I do love turning pages!” (Stephens). This connection with the book is found in the entire reading process, from seeing the words spelled out to turning the pages to fanning the pages to see how

many are left, all the way down to falling asleep while reading the book before bed.

The Film as Primary

Unfortunately, there is no record of the first book adapted for the big screen, but whatever that text might have been, it paved a road lined with Grammys and Academy Awards. In Christine Geraghty's book *Now a Major Motion Picture: Film Adaptations of Literature and Drama*, she poses the argument that adaptations make explicit what seems to be implicit in a book. She defines explicit as "a recognition of ghostly presences and a shadowing or doubling of what is on the surface by what is glimpsed behind" (195). To all who crow that filmmakers twist the plotline, create or kill characters, or morph the original out of shape, this is why.

The medium of visual literature has been sculpted out of the implicit words behind, between, and below the original text. That being understood, this different medium as a new vehicle of literature is now a new experience of the text. As I read *Charlotte's Web*, I came across a passage that was so beautifully written I read it twice. Chapter 19 of the story begins with a scenic description: "Next morning when the first light came into the sky and the sparrows stirred in the trees, when the cows rattled their chains and the rooster crowed and the early automobiles went whispering along the road ..." (144). Each description added to the imaginary scene as I read it; however, I could pinpoint this exact scene in the movie when the screen faded into the beautiful morning. The visual was a new experience as it was given in its entirety rather than pieced together word by word. As soon as I saw this picture, my mind immediately jumped to mornings on the farm when I would pause in moving my irrigation pipe and look at the sun shining in the morning sky, thinking to myself about what a beautiful world I live in. Experiencing a text through a visual medium is not a lazy way to consume; in fact, it can enhance an already beautiful passage into a powerful scene of the film.

The Audiobook as Primary

One of my earliest memories is of hearing the words of an author read aloud to me. I remember lying on my parents' bed with my sister on one side and my dad on the other. I listened to his soothing voice as he read the story of Big Dan and Little Anne and their coon hunting adventures in *Where the*

Red Fern Grows. My father would change his voice for each character, and his tone would reflect the mood of the scene. Through audio, I could devote my entire focus on envisioning the story of the two dogs. My experience with *Charlotte's Web* in audio format was as memorable as listening to my dad.

Audiobooks were first produced in 1935 for blinded war veterans returning home from World War I; Agatha Christie and Joseph Conrad were the first authors whose books were transformed into spoken word (Philips 294–295). It is now considered discriminatory to say that listening to a primary text is not really reading the book. That may be an extreme statement, but that does not make it any less true. Over time, however, what was once produced as a resource for the blind is now marketed as a new medium of literature.

I purchased the audiobook version of E. B. White himself reading *Charlotte's Web* after I had read the original text, and even though the words did not change, the experience of listening to the author read his own words enhanced the story. The parting lines are normally piercing, but in audio format it was an entirely different feeling. Instead of snapping the cover of the book shut in triumph over finishing the text, I sat in thunderous silence as E. B. White read his parting lines about Charlotte: “She was in a class by herself. It is not often that someone comes along who is a true friend and a good writer. Charlotte was both” (184). In an audio format, I was forced to give these lines and the story as a whole a moment of silent reflection before the end credits began. This opportunity is not guaranteed when reading the text in its primary form. The reader sets the pace and gives as little or as much reflection as he or she sees fit, but in audio, the consumer is required to wait, to anticipate the next words. This turns typical reading into active participation with the text.

Video Game as Primary

The list of nontraditional texts is not limited to film and audio. There are countless ways to experience traditional writing via art, music, comics, plays, and even video games. Each one of these unique vehicles of experiencing the text has its own set of pros and cons. I chose to go outside of my box (way outside) and experience *Charlotte's Web* in video game format. I've played video games before; I once spent an evening playing Halo, and I will not lie—I was terrible. However, for one evening I became a character in White's classic tale by spinning my own web of words to save the life of a piglet. I left the realm of merely reading about Charlotte's creations, or even listening

to or watching her spin a web, and I became Charlotte. I chose the words to weave and where to weave them. I left the bystander position of consumer and became a creator along with the author and characters.

Experiencing the text through this medium develops an appreciation for modern technology. A video game may no longer be a way to waste time; it can become a medium of teaching a reader exactly how difficult it is to spin words in a web. In a digital literature study, Anna Gunder claims that “the digitisation of the media scape has affected the nature of ... media migration by giving birth to new artistic forms such as computer games and digital hyperfiction. But it has also provided new means for storage and presentation of texts and works” (Gunder 31). This movement enhances the original work; it creates new means for literature to be consumed, and each format gives the reader a new experience with any passage of text.

Conclusion

There is no longer a solid definition of the primary text because in the modern technological world, a piece of literature can be consumed in multiple ways, and different mediums can become the primary text for readers. Each format connects to the reader in different ways, which means the purpose of reading a text is fulfilled differently to each reader. The themes and overall moral of the story are best processed by whichever format creates the most personal connection with the reader. So next time you pick up a book, experiment a little and pop in a CD of it instead.

About the Author

Five Things Carlie Wallentine loves:

- 1) Flowers
- 2) Stars
- 3) Cowboy Boots
- 4) Snow Storms
- 5) Cooking

Check out Carlie’s blog at <<http://shtcarliesays.blogspot.com/>>

Chapter

**Coon Dogs, Cartoons, and the English Classroom:
How and Why Where the Red Fern Grows Calls for
Visual Representation**

by Amy Whitaker

*“I don’t see why we have to move to town to get an education,” I said.
“Hasn’t Mama taught us how to read and write?” “There’s more to an
education than just reading and writing,” Papa said. “Much more.” —
Wilson Rawls, Where the Red Fern Grows*

Communicating the Emotionality of a Text

Billy, the young coon-hunting protagonist of Wilson Rawls’s *Where the Red Fern Grows*, witnesses the gruesome death of Rubin, a boy from his boondocks community. “Scared, not knowing what to do, I called for Rainie. I got no answer. I called his name again and again. I could get no reply. My voice echoed in the darkness of the silent night. A cold chill ran over my body. I suppose it is natural at a time like that for a boy to think of his mother. I thought of mine. I wanted to get home” (Rawls). I just read *Where the Red Fern Grows* for the seventh or eighth time in my life (it’s a childhood favorite) so that I could research it and write about it for my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class. Often as I read, though, I forgot to think about it as literature as I was caught up in the emotionality of the text: “It is natural at a time like that for a boy to think of his mother.”

Out of curiosity regarding how readers react to this children’s novel filled with weighty issues such as love, death, and family relationships, I began to research informal online responses to *Where the Red Fern Grows*. I looked through Facebook groups; I read tweets; I read book reviews on Goodreads and various other online forums. I searched blogs that mentioned the book

and asked almost everyone I conversed with if they had read the book and what they thought of it. I was disappointed in the surface-level responses I got from each of these sources. In my blog post “Using Art to Interpret Art,” I mention how frustrating it was to hear “What a sad book!” over and over and over again. While *Where the Red Fern Grows* is an easy read, it is replete with feeling—it is full of opportunities to connect with the text in a meaningful, personal way and to explore the intricacies of human emotion and even interspecies relationships. Words, at least the words I found in informal online settings, were inadequate at expressing the readers’ emotions.

These frustrating findings were a pivotal point in my research process.

I decided to see if the internet could provide any visual representations of *Where the Red Fern Grows* that might be more meaningful than the shallow commentary I was finding in written words. I ran across some art inspired by the novel, by illustrator Israel Sanchez. I was moved by the emotion in even his cartoonish depictions (see illustration above). The picture at the heading of this chapter is a fine example of his work. In the written text, as Billy asks for permission from his father to attend the big coon hunt with his grandfather, the hopeful yearning of the adolescent is palpable through the pages. Similarly, in Israel Sanchez’s piece, Billy’s earnest dream—and the dreams of any boy that age—is clearly demonstrated in his cherubic upward gaze at his father.

I emailed Sanchez, and he gave me permission to share his art on my blog, thanking me warmly for my interest in his art and the way he was using it to express his interaction with the work. Thanks to his connection to literature through art and his connection to others through the internet, I was led to school projects (typically at the junior high level) that incorporated visual art into the study of *Where the Red Fern Grows*. As a future high school teacher, I quickly developed a theory that I was thirsty to prove: Visual arts are beneficial for students of secondary education as they study language arts. Indeed, the two arts should not be separated because both textual and visually artistic reactions to the text are legitimate means of interacting with it. *Where the Red Fern Grows* is particularly appropriate for visual representation because of the strong emotions it conveys that sometimes overshadow meaningful themes and somehow dissuade mature, written interactions with the text

Visual Representations and Educational Implications

So, with my theory about education, I decided my best course of action would be to use the internet to contact teachers interested in the topic. Through several forums targeted toward teachers and a discussion I started on Goodreads, I received responses that, for the most part, corroborated my thesis. Various teachers agreed that language arts can be enriched by visual arts, and they encouraged me to continue to pursue this line of thinking (Whitaker, “Responses”). One woman named Cheryl responded on Goodreads that I should consider offering students a choice when I create visual assignments because “some may not be comfortable responding visually” (quoted in Whitaker, “The Incorporation”). I assert that if all students should be expected to create written work, and if we assume that visual creation is beneficial to the learning process, all students can reasonably be expected to create and consume visual work.

Many scholarly sources agree with this viewpoint. Two articles by Zoss and Lin, respectively, state very clearly that visual arts should be a part of mainstream subjects, particularly language arts. I simply wish to take this assertion a step further. Visual arts enrich the study of literature by allowing a greater range of communication, which is especially helpful when exploring highly emotional texts such as *Where the Red Fern Grows*.

The Digitization of a Visual Classroom

Now, this is important. This is the crux of my research. But there is an underlying significance to how I did my research, how I found the art, how I found the lesson plans, how I communicated with Israel, how I reached out to fellow educators, and how I shared what I learned. It was all done online. Even the student art that I found was online. Yes, I read the primary text from a printed book, but most of my interaction with it was virtual. Now, after becoming thoroughly convinced that visual arts are a necessary component of a secondary language arts classroom, I am faced with another question: is technology a necessary part of this visual interaction?

I love the traditional English classroom. I love the smell of books and sitting in a circle, discussing literature. I love whiteboards and notebook paper and that wall-mounted pencil sharpener that sounds as though we’re sharpening our pencils with a chainsaw. But, considering the richness of my digital interaction with *Where the Red Fern Grows*, I can’t just forsake technology when I am a teacher in my own classroom, especially when scholarly sources indicate that technology enhances learning.

In the article “Utilizing the Internet to Facilitate Classroom Learning,” Jan Tucker and Bari Courts state that “there is a push to increase the efficiency of learning and the transfer and facilitation of knowledge. Technology enhanced learning environments improve the learning experience by promoting cooperation, collaboration, and self-sufficiency in learners” (38). Cooperation, collaboration, and self-sufficiency, coupled with a visually-rich classroom, enrich communication, and the level of student interest is bound to increase. Therefore, technology and visual arts are both key components of a great language arts classroom, and just as I saw the two coincide in my research, they should be interwoven in school.

Bringing It All Together

What does this all matter? My research on a single book, *Where the Red Fern Grows*, done through a single—though highly diverse—medium (the internet), led me to a single driving thesis: visual arts are necessary in the study of language arts. How I arrived at this conclusion, though, is as significant as the idea itself when one considers its implications. My ability to access the thoughts of artists, teachers, and typical readers was made possible by the internet. My ability to share my own ideas and get feedback from a variety of interested individuals was also a product of technology. The way I learned about educational interaction with *Where the Red Fern Grows* suggests that secondary education students can also benefit from the richness of digital collaboration. Instead of one-dimensional, read-the-book-and-discuss-it English classrooms, students should be immersed in environments of visual and textual intellectualism, coupled with meaningful collaboration that the digital age makes possible.

About the Author

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Chapter

Jane Eyre and Social Technology: Changing the Learning Process

by Ashley Lewis

*Online forums should be implemented into class curriculum to extend the learning experience of readers. *Disclaimer: Any ideas that are not in quotations are my words and thoughts, not the ideas of those I have used as characters in this chapter.*

Internet forums are online discussion sites where people can hold conversations in the form of posted messages. A single conversation is called a “thread,” such as the thread below: “Why Forums and Why Jane Eyre?” To illustrate the format of forums and the benefits of using forums for learning, this chapter will imitate their format. I will be taking quotations from scholars and placing these into the dialogue format of a forum, as though they were in conversation with me (“Lewis”), my sister (“Natalie”) and with the fictional Jane Eyre. Hopefully, this will convey the vitality of the online forum as a legitimate genre for exploring literature in the digital age.

Why Forums and Why Jane Eyre?

(Lonoff has entered discussion.)

Lonoff: “In Charlotte’s four novels (The Professor, Jane Eyre, Shirley, and Villette), education takes two forms: self-teaching, primarily through reading, and classroom lessons, either at a school or with a governess or tutor” (Lonoff 458).

(Lewis has entered discussion.)

Lewis: Like Lonoff said, self-teaching is a necessary addition to effectively learning information presented in a classroom setting. Technology available today and the technology yet to be invented are transforming the learning

process. Online forums should be implemented into class curriculum because they enable students to deepen and extend the learning experience. The novel *Jane Eyre* supplies a teaching formula leading to an enhanced learning experience.

(Brontë has entered discussion using *Eyre* alias.)

Eyre: Here is the formula Lewis mentioned: “I had the means of an excellent education placed within my reach. A fondness for some of my studies, and a desire to excel in all, together with a great delight in pleasing my teachers, especially such as I loved, urged me on” (Brontë 106).

Lewis: Thank you, Eyre. I feel that this formula for learning also works in the world of forums. The first motive of learning for Jane is a liking for some of the subjects. The second is a desire to excel. The last motive is the most powerful—recognition and feedback from her teachers (Lonoff 462). Technology allows students to explore their subject through their interest in the topic. This personal research leads students to learn the information that is engaging for them, as opposed to class discussion, which usually goes in a direction that is truly engaging for only certain students, or perhaps in some cases, only the teacher. However, instruction is still necessary.

Technology and Teaching

Lewis: Technology should be embraced to help students become self-reliant learners, but teachers should help model the strategies for effective learning (Lonoff 471). Jane’s teacher Miss Temple serves as a role model for her students, especially Jane and Helen. Miss Temple is an accomplished young woman who is still striving to learn all that she can about the world and herself. Most of us remember teachers who really cared about us and our learning, and these were usually the teachers we aimed to please.

Eyre: Lewis is right. For me, that teacher was Miss Temple. She always rose above her expectations as a teacher, making each of her students feel special. I remember the day vividly that Miss Temple first mentioned the possibility of learning the language that I grew to love. “I had meant to be so good, and to do so much at Lowood; to make so many friends, to earn respect, and win affection. Already I had made visible progress: that very morning I had reached the head of my class; Miss Miller had praised me warmly; Miss Temple had smiled approbation; she had promised to teach me drawing, and to let me learn French, if I continued to make similar improvement two months longer” (Bronte 85).

Lewis: Eyre, I understand how you feel. Many of my role models were my

English teachers, who shared with me a common love of literature. Some of these teachers recommended great novels such as *Kite Runner* and the *Bonesetter's Daughter*, books that have made a lasting impression on me.

Some of my teachers (some academic and others not) still teach me lessons today, as I have kept in contact with them through email or social networking sites. We begin to model our learning habits after those teachers. We recognize that to master a subject, we must first imitate that subject's learning process. Students watch teachers analyze and write about a subject and learn how to do so themselves through their teachers' examples. Getting students to close-read a text has always been a struggle. Now, with the new technology of websites and other media tools, literature students discussing *Jane Eyre* may look at clips from video adaptations or discuss how issues of gender, individuality, and the role of the governess are present in the novel (Lonoff 472–473).

Effectiveness of Forum Groups

Lewis: A new media tool for the classroom is and should be online forum groups. As constant learners, we need to remember that we can learn much from those who have different experiences and personalities from ours. A study about the use of online forum groups to supplement the classroom learning experience showed that effective learning takes place when the learning environment is learner-, knowledge-, assessment-, and community-centered. Do you agree or disagree, and why?

(Balaji has entered discussion.)

Balaji: In response to Lewis's question—I agree because “interactivity has been considered as central tenet to the concept of ‘online learning theory’” (Balaji 3).

Lewis: Online resources, such as forums and blogs, allow learners to reflect upon their thinking through interaction with other learners. The learning experience becomes individualized by this deep-level learning and these “new knowledge structures.” These methods of learning communication allow students to learn at their own pace and according to their interests, previous knowledge, and style. Feedback is important for the smooth functioning of these online learning centers.

Community Learning

Lewis: The community component presented on these sites plays a huge

role in online learning. Interaction on these websites gives learners a sense of social connectivity. Just like the personal literary study between Miss Temple and Jane's friend Helen Burns, online forums may provide a more comfortable learning environment for readers than the typical classroom discussion can present. As learners explore and discuss a subject, relationships are formed between the participants.

Balaji: The benefits of relationships between forum members that were discussed by Lewis can be backed up. "Previous research has shown that learning communities exhibit increased student learning, and course satisfaction" (Balaji 3).

Eyre: I have found this to be true from my personal experience, from observing my favorite teacher and my best friend. "They conversed of things I had never heard of; of nations and times past; of countries far away: of secrets of nature discovered or guessed at: they spoke of books: how many they had read! What stores of knowledge they possessed! Then they seemed so familiar with French names and French authors: but my amazement reached its climax when Miss Temple asked Helen if she sometimes snatched a moment to recall the Latin her father had taught her, and taking a book from a shelf, bade her read and construe a page of Virgil; and Helen obeyed, my organ of Veneration expanding at every sounding line" (Bronte 92).

Lewis: It sounds like Helen really shined when discussing ideas with Miss Temple. The same results come from forums. The level of interaction that takes place depends on the learning environment, the learning process, and the learner's characteristics. The lack of nonverbal cues in online discussion forums may lead to less intense interactions, but the lack of cues may unbind the social hierarchy in the online environment, enabling users to have a more equal footing.

What Role Does Personality Play Online?

Lewis: Each individual learner's preparation and personality contribute something different to the forum. Students who have a high understanding of the internet perform their online learning tasks more efficiently, showing the need to teach students how to use the new technological learning tools. The study found that students who had more difficulty using the internet showed low motivation to contribute to the blog simply because of the difficulty for them to share their contributions. Studies of individual personality and internet behavior have revealed that introverted students tend to be more able

to communicate with others in an online environment than face-to-face. Being more of an introvert myself, I can attest to this fact through my blogging experience for my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class and my participation in the blog for my high school book club. This book club was run by our librarian, Mrs. Waltman, another educator who has influenced my understanding of literature through book recommendations and discussions. My communication skills were stronger in the written word; plus, I was able to gather my thoughts and really think out what it was that I was trying to say. Some of the book club members, including myself, were not as diligent as we should have been in using this helpful tool for our learning experience. If we had thrown ourselves into the online discussion group, I am sure that our discussion would have been more complete and enlightening.

Balaji: Forums do allow introverts to verbalize their thoughts in a less intimidating environment. Extroverts are more likely to participate in online discussion forums, though, because of their strong need for gratification and higher success rate of interaction (Balaji 6).

Lewis: I had not really thought about that before. Forums allow all personality types to communicate and learn together. The immediacy of feedback in the online environment gives a greater opportunity for this communication to take place. The sense of connectedness among the learners increases the interactions in the online environment. Media richness theory argues that using appropriate media will improve task performance. Online forums are built to be effective learning communities.

Post, Participate, Ponder

Lewis: Technology gives us a way to connect with each other and extend the learning experience. Listening, disputing, and communicating with one's peers opens students to perspectives and ideas that they would never have thought of themselves. In the classic classroom setting, time serves as a barricade for an array of possible discussions. Social networking has allowed me as a student to easily keep in contact with teachers and professors that have affected the way I learn or simply me as a person. By maintaining this connection, I have been able to continue my personal learning experience.

Eyre: Having the possibility of interacting with others outside of my school sphere was a dream of mine. "I had had no communication by letter or message with the outer world: school-rules, school-duties, school-habits and

notions, and voices, and faces, and phrases, and costumes, and preferences, and antipathies: such was what I knew of existence. And now I felt that it was not enough: I tired of the routine of eight years in one afternoon. I desired liberty” (Bronte 108).

Lewis: I have benefited greatly from the opportunity to interact with others online. For my Writing about Literature in the Digital Age class, each student kept a blog and was expected to interact with classmates through comments on these blogs. Personally, I found a greater satisfaction with the class by having the opportunity to communicate ideas with my peers outside of the classroom setting. We were also encouraged to use other forums, web sites, and media tools. This 24/7 learning method allows students to be actively engaged in the learning process at all times. My sister, Natalie Lewis, has a Master of Education in Technology in Education degree. She has been a full-time teacher of various subjects for the past eight years, and we have discussed the use of technology in the learning process. I will invite her to join our discussion.

(Natalie has entered discussion.)

Natalie: “I have discovered that with the use of technology you can adapt and merge all types of curriculum to have total instructional alignment. Technology used correctly can motivate and engage students in learning. Our student’s present and future experiences are based on technology. The student’s transition from technology to everyday task is seamless. If teachers make a choice to eliminate the use of technology in their classrooms they are limiting the future potential of our students.”

Lewis: Thank you, Natalie. Students have amazing potential, and we should not limit that potential by limiting their resources. After reading articles about multiple studies, speaking with several educators on the subject, and pondering my own personal experience, I believe that online forums should be implemented into the curriculum of all English literature courses. The digital tools are there to enhance the learning experience for readers today. Now is the time for us to use those tools and enhance the learning experience as we grow and learn from one another.

(Lonoff, Lewis, Eyre, Balaji, and Natalie have left the discussionfor now.)

About the Author

Ashley Lewis is a small-town girl trying to make a big difference in the

world and in herself. She is currently attending Brigham Young University to study English. Check out her blog at <http://ashleylewis-oldmeetsnew.blogspot.com/>

Chapter

Big River: The Socialization of Reading and Research in the Digital Age

by BriAnne Zabriskie

The Socialization of Knowledge

Prominent literary critic Harold Bloom writes that “real reading is a lonely activity and does not teach anyone to become a better citizen” (Richter 226). I disagree. Among today’s reading population, reading is no longer “lonely.” As an avid reader in the digital age, I share what I read online, write reviews for my friends and make decisions about what to read based on what they are reading, participate in forums and online discussions with groups of other readers, and so much more. I have even made new friends based on our similar tastes in or opinions about books.

In the digital information age, individuals are increasingly connected not only by social ties but also by ties of information and interests. Online research of a theme in a book is only a few clicks away from the individual who produced that research. I can read a stranger’s review of a book, befriend that stranger, and find more information he or she has produced that may lead me to more people who share our same interest. Knowledge is becoming socialized in a way it never has before, and literary knowledge is swept up in that phenomenon as well. I would argue, because of my experience this semester, that readers are not only limited when they do not allow themselves access to this socially connected knowledge but furthermore, they are not fully informed and cannot experience the text as it exists socially today.

Students of literature must engage in a process of online social inquiry in order to properly engage with a text as it exists today.

My Literary Research Process

Traditional literary reading and research would have us read the paper

copy of a text in isolation, ask several questions about it, do a close-reading explication of it, and find a few articles to corroborate our interpretation. Depending on your method or your instruction, you can rearrange the order of those tasks. I started my academic journey in this way, reading my copy of Mark Twain's *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* and going to the library to search out articles about the subject that I was primarily concerned with: the censorship of the N-word in Alan Gribben's latest edition. As a noted Mark Twain scholar, Gribben has produced a new edition of *Huckleberry Finn* that replaces the word "nigger" with "slave," so as not to offend readers and open up potential audiences (e.g., high schoolers) that the novel might not have had before. This is a hot topic in academic circles right now.

I found an article that interested me from the *Chronicle of Higher Education* entitled "The Redacted 'Huckleberry Finn': 'Chronicle' Bloggers Respond." Intrigued by the summary of several different arguments revolving around the N-word issue, I followed this lead to the *Chronicle's* Blog (DeFattore). I found here that the academic and internet communities interwove: academics wrote, posted these articles online, and anyone who wanted could respond via the comments section, which included dissenting arguments! I followed one comment to the commenter's blog and sent him an email asking more about his opinions. This is just one way information can lead to people, who can lead to more information.

Huck Finn's Social Learning

My research experience reminded me of a theme in the very novel I was researching. *Huckleberry Finn's* friend Tom Sawyer puts a lot of stock in "book learnin'." At several points in the novel, Tom wants to do everything by the book, at one point chastising his friend Ben when he asks why they can't play their game a certain way. Tom says: "Because it ain't in the books so—that's why. Now, Ben Rogers, do you want to do things regular, or don't you?—that's the idea. Don't you reckon that the people that made the books knows what's the correct thing to do? Do you reckon you can learn 'em anything? Not by a good deal" (Twain 11). Huck, however, doesn't begin to really learn until he gets away from a structured school environment and associates with others. It is in long discussions with Jim—his socially acquired knowledge—that Huck learns the most important lesson and decides not to give Jim up to authorities; he discovers that doing what society says is

“right” doesn’t always feel right and decides he’d rather “go to hell” and help a good man become free than betray his friend (Twain 217).

Reading as a Social Process

Just as Huck has to search outside of books to learn the most important lessons of the novel, readers and students of literature must branch out to a wider river of information in order to understand the current social significance of what is read. In my own research journey, I found a plethora of resources that increased my understanding of the novel and involved me in ongoing discussions about it. Listening to the audio version of the novel contextualized the sounds of the dialects I was reading. Searching for syllabi online helped me understand the controversies and issues currently being discussed about the novel. I found a hypertext version of the novel that linked to pictures of the action that helped me to visualize the plot. Searching social streams (such as Twitter) where others were discussing the novel helped me to find interesting things others were doing with the novel and author. Examples of what I found included Google maps of all the important locations in Mark Twain’s life, literary pilgrimages one could take to explore Twain’s life and the novel, photos of original copies of the novel, and even a version of the book translated into barcodes. I also found plenty of blogs and groups discussing themes from the novel.

All of these resources, and more, enriched my study and helped to fully contextualize my understanding of the issues I was researching. I could not have engaged with the novel to the same degree without using these methods of digital and social inquiry. It is necessary for students of literature today to do the same because knowledge is not isolated anymore. The internet makes even reading a social process.

About the Author

BriAnne Zabriskie is a senior English student at Brigham Young University and reads for enjoyment and enlightenment. She will be a first-time mother in July 2011. Her Blog is online at : < <http://brizabriskacademic.blogspot.com/> >

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